TOEFL HOUSE

GRAMMAR FOR SPECIAL SPEAKING

A practical grammar course for accurate, natural, confident speech

Learn the grammar. Use it in conversation. Make it part of your speech.

For Intermediate and Advanced learners

16 lessons · 3 review tests · final assessment · 5 appendices

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Grammar for Special Speaking — TOEFL HOUSE

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Statement of limits

This manuscript has been produced and checked with automated structural and editorial quality gates. Qualified teacher review, classroom piloting, EPUBCheck certification and a commercial print proof are separate steps recorded in the project documentation; none of them is claimed here.

The answer key for learners appears in Appendix 5. Teachers should use the companion Teacher's Book, which contains lesson procedures, full answers with notes, model speaking responses, timing and differentiation guidance.

INTRODUCTION

What this book does and how it works

This book has one purpose: to help you use grammar accurately, naturally and confidently when you speak English.

It is not enough to know a rule. The goal is to turn that knowledge into active speaking skill — to choose the right structure, in the right moment, and say it without thinking about it.

Every lesson follows the same path: you speak first, you learn clear grammar patterns, you see how similar structures differ, you practise, and then you speak again — this time with the new grammar in your voice. Each lesson ends with a short review and a self-check, so you always know what you can already do.

The course works for both Intermediate and Advanced learners in the same room. Everyone studies the same core lesson. The core work builds accuracy; the Advanced Upgrade boxes build flexibility, precision and naturalness. Advanced work rewards appropriate, precise use — never complexity for its own sake.

By the end of the course, you should be able to:

- construct grammatically accurate sentences while speaking;
- choose appropriate tenses and sentence structures for your meaning;
- ask questions and respond with greater precision;
- explain experiences, opinions and hypothetical situations;
- connect ideas into coherent spoken responses;
- use a wider range of structures naturally;
- recognise and correct your recurring grammatical mistakes;
- apply learned structures in unfamiliar speaking situations.

Completion of the sixteen lessons is not proof of these outcomes by itself. The written Diagnostic Test and Final Assessment sample related grammar skills, but they are not parallel tests and their raw totals should not be compared as a measure of gain. For a fairer progress check, use the same speaking task conditions and rubric before and after the course, and compare the four criterion scores.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

For students and teachers

For students

Work through the lessons in order: each one builds on earlier material. Always begin with the Speaking Hook — say your answers out loud before you read the rule. The rule then gives you the tool you were already reaching for.

Do the exercises out loud whenever possible. Grammar becomes speech through the mouth, not only through the eyes. Use the Pair Speaking and Real Talk sections as they are designed: no reading from notes.

After every lesson, cover the page and try the retrieval questions. Tick the self-check honestly. Return to the Formula Book (Appendix 1) whenever you review.

Two pathways, one classroom

Pathway	Focus	What to do
Intermediate — Build Accuracy	guided construction, error correction, short clear responses	complete all core practice; use the Intermediate box in each Advanced Upgrade
Advanced — Build Flexibility	choice between structures, subtle meaning, extended arguments	add the Advanced Upgrade work; in speaking tasks, qualify, counter and connect

Both groups can respond to the same topic at different levels: give a clear opinion with two reasons (Intermediate), or qualify your position, address a counterargument and connect ideas with varied structures (Advanced).

For teachers

Keep grammar explanation short and give learners substantial time to produce spoken English. The suggested pacing below is a guide — adjust it to your class length.

Activity	Minutes (of a 60-minute lesson)
Explanation and examples	15
Controlled practice	10
Pair speaking	20
Independent speaking challenge	10
Feedback and review	5
Total	**60**

Review earlier structures in the review tests and in retrieval practice. Evaluate speaking with the success criteria and the rubric in the Final Assessment — not with rigid model answers. Accept alternative answers where an exercise allows them.

The companion Teacher's Book follows the same sixteen lessons and gives teachers step-by-step procedures for all eight lesson functions, complete answers with explanations, model speaking responses, realistic timings, differentiation and remediation guidance, and common-error notes.

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DIAGNOSTIC TEST

Find your starting point — 25 questions · no time limit

Do this test before Lesson 1. Do not study first: the point is to see what you can already do. Mark your score out of 25 and keep the paper. This is a broad starting snapshot, not a parallel form of the 30-item Final Assessment; do not interpret the difference between their raw totals as a learning gain. For a comparable progress check, complete the speaking sample below and score it with the same rubric used at the end of the book.

Part A — Tenses and time (10 questions)

1. I _____ (see) that film last week.
2. She _____ (work) here since 2021.
3. While I _____ (cook — ongoing background), the phone rang.
4. They _____ (work) there for ten years before they moved to Kabul.
5. At sea level, pure water _____ (boil) at 100°C.
6. They _____ (build) a new bridge when we visited.
7. I _____ my keys — I can't get in. (lose)
8. Last summer we _____ (go) to Herat.
9. How many books _____ you _____ (read) so far this month?
10. When I arrived, the train _____ already _____ (leave).

Part B — Structures (10 questions)

11. If it _____ (rain), we'll stay home.
12. I wish I _____ (know) the answer.
13. My phone needs _____. (repair)
14. The report _____ (write) by the team last week.
15. He suggested _____ early. (leave)
16. Could you tell me where _____ ? (the station / be)
17. The girl _____ helped me was very kind. (who / that / whose / which)
18. I'd rather you _____ (not, smoke) here.
19. Ali is _____ than his brother. (intelligent)
20. Not until midnight _____. (she / finish)

Part C — Use and communication (5 questions)

21. I _____ find my passport anywhere. (mustn't / can't)
22. _____ being very tired, he finished the race. (Despite / Although)
23. She asked me, "Where do you live?" → She asked me _____.
24. It _____ rain later — take an umbrella. (may / might / could)
25. I _____ my hair cut yesterday. (had / got)

Part D — Baseline speaking sample (not included in the 25-point grammar score)

Speak for two minutes

Choose one topic. Prepare for two minutes, then speak for two minutes without reading a script:
• A decision that changed your life — and what you would do differently today.
• One change that would improve education or work in your country.
• A person who influenced you, and the advice they gave you.
After your talk, a partner asks two follow-up questions. Answer them, then ask one relevant question in return. If you get stuck, repair and continue. Record the topic and, if possible, save a recording. At the end of the course, repeat this task under the same conditions. The Final Assessment uses the same task and four-criterion rubric; score this baseline now and score the final sample later.

Criterion	4 — Strong	3 — Good	2 — Developing	1 — Beginning
Grammatical accuracy	structures are consistently accurate; occasional slips do not affect meaning	generally accurate; some errors, meaning always clear	frequent errors; meaning sometimes unclear	errors dominate; meaning often unclear
Appropriate structure selection	wide range used naturally (tenses, conditionals, linkers, hedging…) for the intended meaning	good range; choices usually match the meaning	limited range; some structures forced or inappropriate	basic structures only; frequent wrong choices
Clarity	ideas well organised and easy to follow; effective linking	clear overall; some linking	ideas loosely connected; hard to follow at times	ideas listed without clear connection
Successful communication	message fully delivered; natural delivery, relevant follow-up exchange and self-repair	message delivered; answers and asks relevant follow-ups, with some hesitation	message partly delivered; responses are limited or pauses are long	message largely not delivered; little response to questions

Baseline speaking score: ____ / 16. Keep this page for the matched end-of-course comparison.

When you finish, check your work in Appendix 5. The answer key is kept separate so you can complete the diagnostic without seeing it.

Score guide: 21–25 — strong base, keep the Advanced Upgrade in sight. 15–20 — solid core; work carefully through both pathways. Below 15 — do the core practice twice and speak every answer aloud; accuracy first, speed later.

LESSON 1 · TENSES FOR REAL COMMUNICATION

Part 1 — Build Strong Sentences | Speaking goal: talk about habits, experiences and changes accurately

Tenses are not a chart to memorise — they are choices you make every time you speak.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start here — talk first

Discuss with a partner:
• What do you usually do on a normal weekday? (present simple)
• What are you doing these days to improve your English? (present continuous)
• What did you do last weekend? (past simple)
• What has changed in your life since last year? (present perfect)

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Present tenses: habits, facts and what is happening now

Formula

Present simple: Subject + base verb (+ s/es for he/she/it) → habits · facts · fixed timetables · states
Present continuous: Subject + am/is/are + verb-ing → happening now · current projects · temporary situations · changing trends

Use the present simple when something is generally true or repeated.

Use the present continuous for what is true around this period of your life.

Examples

I work in a clinic.
She studies every evening.
The course starts at eight. (fixed timetable)
I'm working on my pronunciation this month.
More students are learning English online every year. (a change)

Remember

Add -s/-es with he/she/it: he works, she studies, it rains.
Stative verbs usually stay simple: know, believe, own, seem. → 'I know the answer' (not 'I am knowing').

Rule 2 — Past simple vs present perfect

Formula

Past simple: verb-ed / irregular → a finished time
Subject + have/has + past participle → connected to now

Use the past simple for a finished time (yesterday, last year, in 2020, when I was a child).

Use the present perfect for a time period that is still open (today, this week), for an experience or result connected to now, or for a situation that continues to now (often with since or for). 'Recently' can take either tense, depending on the time focus and variety of English.

Examples

I visited Bamyan last summer. (finished)
I have visited Bamyan twice. (experience — no finished time)
She has lived here since 2021. (still true)

Remember

In standard use, a finished-time expression normally takes the past simple: 'I saw him yesterday.' Avoid 'I have seen him yesterday.' With 'recently', either tense can be natural: 'I've seen her recently' / 'I saw her recently'.

Rule 3 — Talking about changes and the future

Formula

going to + base verb → plans and intentions
will + base verb → instant decisions, predictions, promises
present continuous + time word → fixed arrangements

For the near future, choose by meaning: a plan you have decided (going to), a decision you make while speaking (will), or an arrangement (present continuous).

Examples

I'm going to take the TOEFL next year. (plan)
That looks heavy — I'll help you. (decision now)
We're meeting the teacher on Thursday. (arrangement)

Remember

In 'if' and 'when' clauses about the future, use the present simple: 'If it rains, we'll stay home.'

Part 3 · See the Difference

Present perfect vs past simple — the choice is about TIME

Past simple (finished time)	Present perfect (now link)	The difference
I lost my keys yesterday.	I've lost my keys.	The left sentence tells when; the right one is about now (I still don't have them).
She worked there for five years. (she doesn't now)	She has worked there for five years. (she still does)	Past simple = finished period. Present perfect = continuing to now.
When did you arrive?	Have you arrived yet?	Past simple asks for a finished time; present perfect asks about the present result.

State verbs vs action verbs

A state verb describes a condition, not an action: know, understand, believe, belong, own, seem, prefer.

These usually take simple forms: 'I understand the rule' — not 'I am understanding the rule'.

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete or correct the sentences.

1. I _____ (see) that film last week.
2. Nadia _____ (work) at the hospital since 2022.
3. We _____ (meet) the new teacher tomorrow at ten. (arrangement)
4. Look! It _____ (snow)!
5. My brother _____ (believe) in hard work.

B. Choose, transform or build.

1. Correct the mistake: 'I have finished my homework last night.'
2. Correct the mistake: 'She is knowing the answer.'
3. Choose: How long (do you know / have you known) Sara?
4. Rewrite with going to: 'I intend to study medicine.'

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Work with a partner

Interview your partner. Listen carefully and ask one follow-up question each time.
• What do you usually do at the weekend?
• What are you doing these days that is new?
• What did you do last night?
• What has changed in your life since last year?
Expected output: Both partners answer all four questions, exchange at least four follow-up questions in total, and can report one interesting answer about the other person to the class.

Success criteria

✓ uses present simple for habits
✓ uses present continuous for current situations
✓ uses past simple and present perfect with correct time words
✓ asks one natural follow-up question

Part 6 · The Advanced Upgrade

Intermediate — build accuracy

• Drill the time cues: yesterday / ago / in 2020 → past simple; since / for → present perfect when the situation continues to now; this week → often present perfect while the period is open.
• Make three true sentences about yourself: one habit, one current project, one recent experience.

Advanced — build flexibility

• Use the present perfect continuous for the activity itself: 'I've been revising all morning.' (and I'm tired)
• Use past simple + present perfect in one sentence: 'I failed twice, but I've learned from both failures.'
• Use 'It's the first time I've...' and 'This is the most ... I've ever ...' for emphasis.

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Plan first

Planning (30 seconds): choose three time anchors — one habit (present simple), one change up to now (present perfect), one activity of these days (present continuous). Write keywords only, not sentences.

Speak now — without reading

Speak for one minute: how has your English improved? Name one specific past event, explain what you learned from it, and say what you are still working on now.

Model response — speak first, then compare; one strong example, not the only answer

I've been studying English seriously for about two years. Last year I joined a speaking club, and that was the moment things changed — I learned to think in English instead of translating every sentence. These days I listen to a short podcast every morning, and I'm still working on my pronunciation. My grammar is much better than it was, but speaking fluently is what I'm focusing on now.

Partner feedback — listen for

✓ past simple for the specific event
✓ present perfect for the change up to now
✓ present continuous for what is happening these days
✓ clear time expressions (last year, since..., this month)

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Key learning points

• Present simple = facts and habits. Present continuous = around now.
• Past simple = finished time. Present perfect = connected to now.
• going to = plan; will = decision now or prediction; present continuous = arrangement.

Retrieval practice — cover the page, then say

• Say your last weekend in five past-simple sentences.
• Say three things that have changed in your life since 2020.

Watch out

• 'I have seen him yesterday' → 'I saw him yesterday.'
• 'I am knowing' → 'I know.'

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can talk about a habit, a current project and a past experience in one answer.

☐ I chose past simple vs present perfect correctly in the practice.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 1 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

A. saw has worked / has been working are meeting is snowing believes
B. I finished my homework last night. She knows the answer. have you known I'm going to study medicine.

LESSON 2 · TELLING STORIES AND DESCRIBING EXPERIENCES

Part 1 — Build Strong Sentences | Speaking goal: tell a story with background, sequence and clear focus

Good stories have a shape: background first, main events in order, one moment of focus.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start here — talk first

Tell your partner a short story (30 seconds): something funny, surprising or important that happened to you.
Now listen to your partner's story. Which moment felt most important? What made it clear?

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Past continuous: the background of a story

Formula

Subject + was/were + verb-ing
Use it for: the background · what was happening when something started

The past continuous paints the scene. The past simple puts the events into it.

Examples

I was walking home when I met an old friend.
The sun was setting and the streets were getting quiet.

Remember

'when' usually takes the past simple; 'while' usually takes the past continuous: 'While I was cooking, the lights went out.'

Rule 2 — Past perfect: the earlier past

Formula

Subject + had + past participle
Use it for: the first of two past actions · background that happened before the story

When you tell a story, the past perfect takes the reader one step further back.

Examples

By the time we arrived, the film had already started.
She looked upset because she had lost her wallet.

Remember

After 'by the time', use past simple for the second action: 'By the time the taxi came, we had packed everything.'

Rule 3 — Sequencing a story clearly

Formula

First ... Then ... After that ... Suddenly ... Finally ...
Earlier that day ... · By the time ... · As soon as ...

Sequence words are the signposts of a story. Without them, listeners get lost.

Examples

First, we waited at the gate. Then, suddenly, the announcement came.
As soon as I opened the letter, I understood everything.

Remember

'as soon as' = the second action happens immediately after the first.

Part 3 · See the Difference

Past simple vs past continuous vs past perfect

Past simple — the events	Past continuous — the scene	Past perfect — the earlier past	What each does
I cooked dinner.	I was cooking dinner when she called.	I had cooked dinner before she arrived.	Simple = the event. Continuous = the scene. Perfect = the earlier action.
He took a taxi.	He was taking a taxi when it broke down.	He had taken a taxi before the rain started.	Each form places the action at a different level of the story.

Story shape: background → event → reflection

Strong stories do three things: set the scene (past continuous), report what happened (past simple), and look back (past perfect or present perfect): 'It was raining… I slipped… I had never been so embarrassed… I've been careful ever since.'

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete or correct the sentences.

1. While I _____ (study), the power went off.
2. We _____ (already / eat) when they arrived.
3. First, I _____ (call) the office. Then I _____ (take) a bus.
4. She _____ (walk) along the river when she _____ (see) the smoke.
5. By 2019, he _____ (finish) his degree.
6. The children _____ (play) outside while their mother _____ (rest).

B. Choose, transform or build.

1. Combine with while: I read the report. The printer broke.
2. Combine with by the time: We reached the station. The train had left. (use past perfect)
3. Correct: 'When I arrived, he already left.'
4. Add sequence words: tell a three-sentence story about missing a bus.
5. Choose: The phone rang (while / when) I was having a bath.
6. Rewrite as a story scene: 'It rained. I forgot my umbrella. I got wet.' (use past continuous + past simple)

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Work with a partner

Tell a two-minute story from your life. Your partner listens, then asks two follow-up questions.
• Choose: a journey you remember · a day everything went wrong · an important decision you made quickly.
• Include one background scene (past continuous), one earlier action (past perfect), and one final reflection.
Expected output: Each partner tells a two-minute story that the other can retell in three sentences, and asks two genuine follow-up questions about it.

Success criteria

✓ background scene is clear
✓ events follow a logical order with sequence words
✓ past perfect marks the earlier action
✓ ending explains why the moment mattered

Part 6 · The Advanced Upgrade

Intermediate — build accuracy

• Drill the three levels: background (was/were + -ing), events (past simple), earlier past (had + participle).
• Tell a 30-second story using exactly one 'while', one 'when' and one 'by the time'.

Advanced — build flexibility

• Use 'would' for repeated past habits in a story: 'On summer evenings, we would sit outside and talk.'
• Use 'had been doing' for earlier background activity: 'She had been waiting for an hour when the bus finally came.'
• End a story with a present reflection: 'It taught me a lesson I've never forgotten.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Plan first

Plan (ten seconds only — nothing written): fix the shape of the story — background scene, two main events, one earlier action, one ending that explains why the day mattered.

Speak now — without reading

Tell a two-minute story: a memorable day in your life. Plan it for ten seconds only — do not write anything. Tell it again to a second partner, better.

Model response — speak first, then compare; one strong example, not the only answer

It was a Friday in May. I was walking home from the market when I realised I had left my phone at home — I had only been walking for ten minutes, so I turned back at once. First I checked the path behind me; then I hurried home. By the time I reached the flat, my sister had already answered a call from my cousin: he had won two tickets to the final and needed my answer straight away. I called him back immediately, and we went that night. I've checked my pockets before leaving the house ever since.

Partner feedback — listen for

✓ background + main events + ending (clear story shape)
✓ sequence words (first, then, suddenly, finally)
✓ past continuous and past perfect used accurately
✓ the listener can repeat the story's main events in order

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Key learning points

• Past continuous = the scene; past simple = the events; past perfect = the earlier past.
• Sequence words make a story easy to follow.
• A good story ends with why it mattered.

Retrieval practice — cover the page, then say

• Tell a story with exactly one 'while' and one 'by the time'.
• What is the three-part shape of a strong story?

Watch out

• 'When I arrived, he left.' (wrong order) → 'When I arrived, he had left.'
• 'While I was walking, I had seen…' → 'While I was walking, I saw…'

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ My story has a clear background, order and ending.

☐ I used past perfect for the earlier action.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 2 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

A. was studying had already eaten called / took was walking / saw had finished were playing / was resting
B. While I was reading the report, the printer broke. By the time we reached the station, the train had left. When I arrived, he had already left. answers vary while It was raining and I forgot my umbrella, so I got wet. (answers vary)

LESSON 3 · QUESTIONS, AUXILIARY VERBS, AND FOLLOW-UP QUESTIONS

Part 2 — Express Ideas Clearly | Speaking goal: ask clear questions and keep a conversation alive

A conversation is a game of questions. The person who asks well controls the talk — politely.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start here — talk first

With a partner, find out: their favourite way to relax, something they are learning now, and one plan for the future.
Rule for this round: after every answer, ask ONE follow-up question before you speak about yourself.

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Forming questions

Formula

Yes/No question: Auxiliary + subject + verb ...?
Wh- question: Wh- word + auxiliary + subject + verb ...?
Auxiliaries: be · have · do · will · can · should · would ...

Most direct English questions put an auxiliary verb before the subject. A subject question is a key exception: 'Who called you?' (who is the subject, so there is no inversion).

Examples

Do you live here? · Are you ready? · Have you finished?
Where do you live? · What happened? (What = subject — no auxiliary inversion)
Who called you? (Who = subject)

Remember

With 'do/does/did', use the base verb after it: 'Did she call?' (not 'Did she called?')

Rule 2 — Direct and indirect (polite) questions

Formula

Direct: Where is the bank?
Indirect: Could you tell me where the bank is?
Embedded order: question word + subject + verb (no inversion!)

Indirect questions use statement word order. They sound polite and professional.

Examples

Do you know how much this costs?
I'd like to know when the results will be announced.
Could you tell me why the schedule changed?

Remember

'Do you know where is the bank?' is wrong. → 'Do you know where the bank is?'

Rule 3 — Follow-up questions: the engine of conversation

Formula

Really? · What happened next? · How about you? · What do you mean?
Why was that? · How did that feel? · What are you going to do about it?

Follow-up questions show you listened. They are the difference between an interview and a conversation.

Examples

A: I changed my job last month. B: Wow — how is it going so far?
A: I failed the first time. B: That's hard. What will you do differently?

Remember

Ask about the CONTENT of the answer, not only the topic. Content follow-ups sound genuine: 'You said it was difficult — what part was hardest?'

Part 3 · See the Difference

Direct vs indirect questions

Direct	Indirect (polite)	Why
Where did you buy it?	Could you tell me where you bought it?	Indirect = polite; notice the statement word order after 'where'.
What time does it open?	Do you know what time it opens?	After 'do you know', the tense can stay, but the word order changes.
Why are you late?	Would you mind telling me why you're late?	Soft openings turn a sharp question into a polite one.

Question word is subject vs object

'Who broke the window?' (Who = subject → no 'did'). Compare: 'Who did you call?' (you = subject).

This is a very common error at every level.

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete or correct the sentences.

1. _____ you ever _____ (try) Afghan pilau?
2. What _____ (happen) at the meeting yesterday?
3. Do you know where _____ ? (the library / be)
4. Could you tell me how much this _____ ? (cost)
5. Who _____ (write) this report?
6. Who _____ you _____ (write) to yesterday?

B. Choose, transform or build.

1. Make the question polite: 'Where did you park?'
2. Make the question polite: 'When will the results be ready?'
3. Correct: 'Do you know where is the bank?'
4. Add two follow-ups: 'I'm planning to change careers.'
5. Correct: 'Did she called you?'
6. Write one question with 'How long…' about English study.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Work with a partner

Three-minute interview. Partner A asks; Partner B answers — but every answer must end with a follow-up question back to A. Then swap.

• Choose 3 topics: learning English · a proud moment · a difficult decision · future plans.
• Use at least one indirect question and three follow-up questions per person.

Expected output: A three-minute exchange per pair in each role: three answers, at least three content-based follow-ups, one indirect question — then a one-sentence summary of what you learned about your partner.

Success criteria

✓ question word order is correct (direct and indirect)
✓ follow-ups react to the content of the answers
✓ the conversation flows — no long silences
✓ each person speaks about the same amount

Part 6 · The Advanced Upgrade

Intermediate — build accuracy

• Drill the two orders: 'Where did you go?' vs 'Do you know where you went?'
• Learn five soft openers: Could you tell me… · Do you happen to know… · Would you mind telling me… · I was wondering… · Do you have any idea…

Advanced — build flexibility

• Negative questions show surprise: 'Haven't we met before?' · 'Didn't you get my message?'
• Echo questions show interest: 'You did WHAT?' · 'She said it how?'
• Question tags keep a conversation shared: 'It's getting late, isn't it?' · 'You've met her, haven't you?'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Plan first

Plan (30 seconds): ready two one-sentence stories of your own, one indirect question you can ask whatever the topic is, and three reactions: Really? · What happened next? · How about you?

Speak now — without reading

Two-minute conversation challenge: your partner will say only one sentence to start (for example: 'I almost missed my flight last week.'). Keep the conversation alive for two full minutes using only questions and short reactions.

Model response — speak first, then compare; one strong example, not the only answer

A: I almost missed my flight last week.
B: Really? What happened next?
A: The traffic was terrible — I reached the gate twenty minutes before take-off. Do you often fly, or was this a one-off?
B: I fly for work sometimes. What's the worst journey you've ever had?
A: A train was cancelled once, so I waited six hours at the station. Have you ever missed a connection?
B: No, but I came close in Dubai. How did you get through the wait in the end?

Partner feedback — listen for

✓ asks real follow-up questions (about content, not only topic)
✓ uses at least one indirect question
✓ correct question word order
✓ the conversation never stops

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Key learning points

• Questions need an auxiliary before the subject — except when the question word is the subject.
• Indirect questions use statement word order: 'Do you know where the bank is?'
• Follow-up questions keep conversations alive.

Retrieval practice — cover the page, then say

• Ask one direct and one indirect question about the same thing.
• Say three follow-up questions you could use with any partner.

Watch out

• 'Do you know where is the bank?' → 'Do you know where the bank is?'
• 'Did she called?' → 'Did she call?'

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can form polite questions with correct word order.

☐ I can keep a conversation going with follow-ups.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 3 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

A. have / tried happened the library is costs wrote did / write
B. Could you tell me where you parked? Do you know when the results will be ready? Do you know where the bank is? answers vary Did she call you? answers vary

LESSON 4 · MODAL VERBS FOR REAL-LIFE SITUATIONS

Part 2 — Express Ideas Clearly | Speaking goal: express ability, advice, obligation, permission, possibility and certainty at the right strength

Modals are the volume knobs of English: they control how strong or soft your message is.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start here — talk first

Give advice to a friend who says: 'My English is not improving.' Use at least two modals (should, could, might…).
A student asks you: 'Can I leave the class early?' Answer politely with a modal.

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — The core modals

Formula

Modal + base verb (no -s, no to: he can swim / not he cans or he can to swim)
can / could = ability · may / could = permission · must / have to = obligation
should / ought to = advice · might / could / may = possibility

Choose the modal by meaning and by how strong you want to be.

Examples

I can speak three languages. (ability)
You should rest. (advice — soft)
You must submit the form by Friday. (strong obligation)
It might rain later. (possibility)

Remember

'have to' is often about external rules; 'must' about the speaker's own strong belief: 'I have to wear a uniform' (the rules say so) · 'You must see this film!' (I strongly recommend it).

Rule 2 — Degrees of certainty

Formula

must be / must have been = almost certainly (positive deduction)
might / could / may be = possible
can't be / couldn't have been = almost certainly not

When you guess based on evidence, the modal shows how sure you are. For the past: must have + participle / might have + participle / can't have + participle.

Examples

She's not answering. She must be in a meeting.
He might have missed the bus.
He can't be at home — his car is gone.

Remember

mustn't = prohibition ('You mustn't tell anyone'); can't = deduction ('He can't be 40!'). These are completely different.

Rule 3 — Politeness in real life

Formula

Would you mind + -ing …? · Could I possibly …? · Would it be all right if I …?
I was wondering if I could … (very polite)

In professional and formal situations, softer modals protect relationships.

Examples

Would you mind closing the window?
Could I possibly move the deadline by one day?
I was wondering if I could ask for your advice.

Remember

'Would you mind + -ing' — the answer 'No' means 'yes, fine': 'Would you mind waiting?' — 'No, not at all.'

Part 3 · See the Difference

must vs have to vs should

must (strong advice)	have to (external rule)	should (gentle advice)	What it shows
You must see a doctor.	You have to see a doctor.	You should see a doctor.	Strong advice from the speaker / external requirement / gentle advice.
He must be tired.	He has to be tired.	—	Deduction (I'm sure) vs requirement (the rules force him).

can't (deduction) vs mustn't (prohibition)

can't = I'm sure it's not	mustn't = forbidden	The difference
He can't be home yet.	He mustn't leave yet.	can't = I'm sure it is not true. mustn't = I forbid it / it is forbidden.

could vs was able to

'Could' describes general ability ('I could swim when I was five'); for one successful past achievement, use 'was able to': 'After an hour, I was able to solve it.'

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete or correct the sentences.

1. You look tired. You _____ get some rest. (advice)
2. She _____ speak four languages when she was twelve. (past ability)
3. He _____ be at work — his car is in the car park. (certainty, positive)
4. You _____ touch the wires — it's dangerous! (prohibition)
5. It _____ rain later; take an umbrella. (50% possibility)
6. _____ you mind _____ (open) the window?

B. Choose, transform or build.

1. Rewrite politely: 'Open the window.'
2. Rewrite with deduction: 'I'm sure she is at home.'
3. Rewrite with deduction (past): 'Perhaps he missed the train.'
4. Correct: 'He mustn't be at home — his lights are off.' (meaning: I'm sure he is not)
5. Answer naturally: 'Would you mind waiting five minutes?'
6. Give soft advice to someone with a headache (2 sentences with modals).

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Work with a partner

Agree on an answer together. Speak as professionals solving a real problem.
• Scenario: your team must choose ONE: a weekend trip, a new project, a training course. There is a budget and a time limit.
• Use modals to negotiate: suggest (should), offer (could), insist (must), accept possibility (might), refuse softly.
Expected output: One agreed decision per pair, justified with at least three different modals, plus two polite request forms used naturally during the negotiation.

Success criteria

✓ modals show the right strength (advice vs obligation)
✓ polite forms used at least twice (Would you mind… / Could I…)
✓ certainty language used correctly (must be / might be)
✓ a decision is reached and explained

Part 6 · The Advanced Upgrade

Intermediate — build accuracy

• Sort modals by job, not on one fixed scale: must be = strong deduction; should be = expectation; may/might/could be = possibilities. Compare the meaning in context.
• Practise the three deductions: must be / might be / can't be — about people in the room.

Advanced — build flexibility

• Use 'must have + participle' for past deduction: 'You must have been exhausted.'
• Use 'would' for polite preference: 'I'd suggest waiting.' · 'Would you prefer tea or coffee?'
• Use hedged obligation for diplomacy: 'We really ought to consider…' · 'It might be worth revisiting…'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Plan first

Planning (one minute): decide your role, your goal or main complaint, two polite request forms you will use, and one deduction you can make from visible evidence. Swap roles after one minute.

Speak now — without reading

Role-play: a client calls with a problem (a delayed order, a bad hotel room, a missed class). One of you is the client (complain with modals); one is the professional (advise, apologise, negotiate with modals). Swap roles after one minute.

Model response — speak first, then compare; one strong example, not the only answer

Client: Good morning — I was wondering if I could talk about my order. It was due on Tuesday, and it still hasn't arrived.
Professional: I'm sorry about that. You must be frustrated. Let me check… It looks like the parcel was sent to the wrong depot.
Client: In that case, could I have it redelivered tomorrow? I have to be at work, so it might need to come after five.
Professional: That should be possible. We could offer an evening slot, or I could ask the depot to hold it for collection. Which would you prefer?

Partner feedback — listen for

✓ modals match the intended strength
✓ polite professional language
✓ at least one deduction (must be / can't be)
✓ a clear solution is offered

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Key learning points

• Modals + base verb. Choose by meaning: ability, advice, obligation, permission, possibility.
• must be / might be / can't be = degrees of certainty; mustn't ≠ can't.
• Softer modals (could, would, might) make requests and advice polite.

Retrieval practice — cover the page, then say

• Say three deductions about the room (must / might / can't).
• Ask for something very politely using two different soft forms.

Watch out

• 'He mustn't be at home' (I forbid) — if you mean deduction, say 'He can't be at home'.
• 'Would you mind to open…?' → 'Would you mind opening…?'

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I chose the right modal strength in the role-play.

☐ I can give polite advice and deductions with correct forms.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 4 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

A. should could must mustn't might Would / opening
B. Could you open the window, please? / Would you mind opening the window? She must be at home. He might have missed the train. / He may have missed the train. He can't be at home — his lights are off. No, not at all. (No problem.)

answers vary

REVIEW TEST 1

Cumulative review — Lessons 1–4 · 15 questions · suggested time: 20 minutes

Part A — Complete the sentences.

1. I _____ (not/see) him since Monday.
2. While we _____ (wait — ongoing action), the announcement came.
3. At standard atmospheric pressure, pure water _____ (freeze) at 0°C.
4. She _____ (study) medicine these days.
5. By the time we arrived, the guests _____ (eat) everything.
6. Look at the sky — it _____ (rain).
7. How long _____ you _____ (know) Nadia?
8. Before the meeting _____ (start), we had already discussed the plan.

Part B — Rewrite, combine or transform.

1. You _____ wear a seat belt; it's the law. (must / might)
2. _____ you mind _____ (close) the door?
3. Do you know where the post office _____ ? (be)
4. You _____ bring any food; we will provide everything. (not / have to)

Part C — Use and communication.

1. Give advice: A friend is exhausted but has a long drive. (use should)
2. Make it polite: 'Where did you park?' (Could you tell me…)
3. Give a deduction: You see a colleague carrying a tennis racket. 'You _____ (be) on your way to a game.'

When you finish, check your work in Appendix 5. The answers are kept separate so you can complete the test without seeing them.

LESSON 5 · CONDITIONALS FOR DECISIONS AND POSSIBILITIES

Part 3 — Think Beyond the Present | Speaking goal: talk about consequences, alternatives and hypothetical situations accurately

Conditionals are the grammar of thinking ahead — and of imagining other worlds.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start here — talk first

Quick answers with a partner:
• What will you do if you pass your exam?
• What would you do if you had one free year?
• What would you have done differently last year if you could?

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Zero and first conditional: real situations

Formula

Zero: If + present simple, present simple (facts)
First: If + present simple, will + base verb (ordinary real future possibility)

The zero conditional is for facts and automatic results. The first is for real future possibilities and their consequences.

Examples

If you heat ice, it melts. (zero — under ordinary conditions)
If it rains, we'll stay home. (first — real possibility)

Remember

In an ordinary future condition, use present simple in the if-clause: 'If it rains, we'll stay home.' Do not use will just because the event is future. Will can occur in if-clauses with a meaning such as willingness, but that is a different pattern.

Rule 2 — Second conditional: unreal or unlikely present

Formula

If + past simple, would + base verb
Use it for: imaginary situations · unlikely futures · advice

The second conditional imagines a different present — or a future that is unlikely.

Examples

If I were you, I'd accept the offer. (advice)
If I had more time, I would learn the piano.

Remember

'If I were you...' is the conventional standard form in advice. Was also occurs in informal English: 'If I was you...'.

Rule 3 — Third and mixed conditionals: unreal past

Formula

Third: If + past perfect, would have + participle (unreal past)
Mixed: If + past perfect, would + base verb (past cause → present result)
Mixed: If + past simple, would have + participle (present cause → past result)

The third conditional looks back at a past that never happened. Mixed conditionals connect a past cause to a present result (or the reverse).

Examples

If I had left earlier, I wouldn't have missed the flight. (third)
If I had studied medicine, I would be a doctor now. (mixed)
If I were more careful, I wouldn't have lost my phone. (mixed)

Remember

In speech, native speakers often shorten: 'If I'd known...' · '...we'd have left.'

Rule 4 — Variations worth knowing

Formula

Unless = if not · As long as / provided (that) = only if
Should + subject + verb = very formal first conditional
Were + subject + … = formal second conditional

'Unless you hurry, you'll miss the bus.' = 'If you don't hurry…'

'Should you need help, call this number.' (formal)

Examples

You won't pass unless you practise.
I'll come as long as you wait for me.

Remember

'unless' already contains 'not' — don't add another negative.

Part 3 · See the Difference

Second vs third conditional

Second — unreal present	Third — unreal past	The difference
If I had time, I would help you.	If I had had time, I would have helped you.	Now/unreal vs past/unreal. The helping didn't happen in the third.
If I were rich, I would travel.	If I had been rich, I would have travelled.	Imagined present vs imagined past.

Type 3 vs mixed

Third conditional	Mixed (past → present)	The difference
If I had slept earlier, I would have arrived on time. (both past)	If I had slept earlier, I would be fresh now. (past → present)	Mixed conditionals are simply cause and result in different times.

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete or correct the sentences.

1. If you _____ (heat) pure water at sea level to 100°C, it _____ (boil).
2. If it _____ (rain) tomorrow, we _____ (cancel) the trip.
3. If I _____ (be) you, I _____ (apologise).
4. If she _____ (leave) earlier, she _____ (not/miss) the train yesterday.
5. If I _____ (know) his number, I _____ (call) him now.
6. We _____ (go) for a walk as long as the weather _____ (stay) fine.

B. Choose, transform or build.

1. Rewrite with unless: 'If you don't register, you can't attend.'
2. Rewrite as a third conditional: 'He didn't study, so he failed.'
3. Rewrite as a mixed conditional (past → present): 'She didn't save money, so she can't buy the car now.'
4. Correct: 'If I will have time, I will help you.'
5. Give advice (2nd conditional): a friend wants to quit their job tomorrow without a plan.
6. Answer naturally: What would you do if you won a large prize?

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Work with a partner

Build one story together, sentence by sentence, using conditionals. Each person adds one sentence and passes the story on.

- Start: 'If I had woken up early this morning…'
- Continue for at least six sentences, mixing 2nd, 3rd and mixed conditionals.
- Then invent a second chain starting 'If the internet stopped working tomorrow…'

Expected output: One shared story of at least six linked conditional sentences per pair, including one third and one mixed conditional, that both partners can retell in summary.

Success criteria

✓ conditional forms are accurate
✓ at least one third and one mixed conditional appear
✓ the story makes logical sense
✓ both partners contribute equally

Part 6 · The Advanced Upgrade

Intermediate — build accuracy

- Memorise one living example per type: 'If you heat ice, it melts.' / 'If it rains, we'll cancel.' / 'If I were you, I'd wait.' / 'If I'd known, I'd have come.'
- Drill the short forms in speech: If I'd… · I'd have… · we wouldn't have…

Advanced — build flexibility

- Use inverted conditionals for formal emphasis: 'Had I known…' · 'Were I in your position…' · 'Should you require assistance…'
- Use 'but for + noun' instead of a full if-clause: 'But for your help, I would have failed.'
- Use 'suppose / supposing (that)…' for playful hypotheses: 'Suppose you had to leave tomorrow — what would you take?'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Plan first

Planning (30 seconds): give each conditional type a job — first for real consequences, second for the unlikely option, third or mixed for last year's mistake. Note only the verbs you will need.

Speak now — without reading

Decision talk (one minute): imagine your organisation has extra money. Choose between three options (training, new equipment, a trip). Explain what will happen if you choose each one — and what you would have done differently last year with this money.

Model response — speak first, then compare; one strong example, not the only answer

If we choose training, the team will improve their skills, but we will have to postpone the equipment purchase. New equipment would help more in the short term, although if I were on the committee, I would invest in people first. If I had been on it last year, I would have set aside a training budget monthly — then we wouldn't be choosing one thing over another now. So my choice is training, and I'd approve it today.

Partner feedback — listen for

✓ first conditional for real consequences
✓ second conditional for unlikely options
✓ third or mixed conditional for the past reflection
✓ clear, logical reasoning

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Key learning points

- Zero = facts; first = real future; second = unreal present; third = unreal past; mixed = two times.
- 'If I were you…' is the standard advice frame.
- In an ordinary future condition, use present simple in the if-clause.

Retrieval practice — cover the page, then say

- Say one example of each conditional type (5 sentences).
- Turn one past regret into a third conditional sentence.

Watch out

- 'If it will rain…' → 'If it rains…'
- 'unless you don't hurry' → 'unless you hurry'

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can tell an unreal past situation (3rd) and a past→present link (mixed).

☐ I use present simple after if for ordinary future conditions.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 5 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

A. heat / boils rains / will cancel (or: 'll cancel) were / would apologise had left / wouldn't have missed knew / would call will go / stays
B. Unless you register, you can't attend. If he had studied, he wouldn't have failed. If she had saved money, she could buy the car now. / …would be able to buy… If I have time, I will help you. answers vary answers vary

LESSON 6 · WISHES, REGRETS, AND HYPOTHETICAL SITUATIONS

Part 3 — Think Beyond the Present | Speaking goal: express preferences, dissatisfaction, regrets and imagined alternatives naturally

English has special grammar for the world as you wish it were. This lesson gives it to you.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start here — talk first

Complete honestly and tell your partner:
• I wish I had more time for...
• I wish I could...
• I regret not...

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — wish about the present

Formula

wish + past simple → I wish I knew. (but I don't)
wish + could / would + base verb → ability or change

Use the past form for a present situation you want different. The time is now; the grammar steps back one level.

Examples

I wish I spoke French fluently. (I don't)
I wish I were taller. (were is the traditional subjunctive and common in careful English; was is also widespread informally: I wish I was taller.)
I wish I could help you. (but I can't)

Remember

Use wish + would for a desired change in behaviour or situation, often one outside your control; it can sound like a complaint: 'I wish you would stop interrupting.' For ability, use could: 'I wish I could help.'

Rule 2 — wish about the past (regret)

Formula

wish + past perfect → I wish I had studied. (but I didn't)

For regrets about the past, use 'had + participle'. This is the grammar of 'if only I had known...'

Examples

I wish I had taken that job.
If only we had left earlier!

Remember

'If only...!' is more emotional than 'I wish...'.

Rule 3 — would rather and it is time

Formula

would rather + base verb → my own preference
would rather + past simple → someone else's action (polite pressure)
It is (high) time + past simple → it should already be happening
It is time + subject + past simple · It is time to + base verb

'I'd rather stay home.' (my choice) · 'I'd rather you stayed home.' (your choice — notice past form).

'It's time we left.' (= we are late leaving).

Examples

I'd rather cook than order food.
I'd rather you didn't smoke here.
It's high time we started the meeting.

Remember

'had better' = strong advice about the near future: 'You'd better hurry.' It is not the past of 'better'.

Rule 4 — prefer, as if / as though

Formula

prefer A to B · would prefer to X rather than Y
as if / as though + past simple (unreal now) or past perfect (unreal past)

'as if' introduces how something seems — often not real: 'He talks as if he knew everything.' (he probably doesn't).

Examples

I prefer tea to coffee.
She looked as if she had seen a ghost.

Remember

If the comparison is real, keep the tense normal: 'It looks as if it is going to rain.' (probably true)

Part 3 · See the Difference

wish + past vs wish + past perfect

wish + past — now	wish + past perfect — then	The difference
I wish I had a car.	I wish I had bought that car.	Present wish vs past regret. The grammar tells you which world you are in.
I wish I knew the answer.	I wish I had known the answer.	Now vs then.

wish + would vs wish + could

wish + could (ability)	wish + would (willingness)	The difference
I wish I could come.	I wish you would come.	could = ability (about me). would = willingness or change (often about you — complaint or request).

it's time: three shapes

'It's time to go.' (general) · 'It's time we went.' (we are late) · 'It's high time he apologised.' (strong: this should already have happened)

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete or correct the sentences.

1. I wish I _____ (know) her phone number.
2. I wish I _____ (not/say) that yesterday.
3. She acts as if she _____ (own) the place.
4. It's high time we _____ (make) a decision.
5. I'd rather you _____ (not/tell) anyone.
6. If only I _____ (be) more patient!

B. Choose, transform or build.

1. Rewrite as a regret (3rd conditional feel): 'I didn't study harder. Now I regret it.' (use wish)
2. Rewrite politely: 'Stop smoking here.' (use would rather)
3. Correct: 'I wish I have more time.'
4. Correct: 'It's time we will go.'
5. Choose: I prefer (reading / to read) novels rather than (watch / watching) films.
6. Describe something unreal with 'as if': your friend arrived late and covered in mud.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Work with a partner

The complaint-and-fix game. One partner describes things they are unhappy about (using wish). The other offers solutions (using should / could / it's time). Swap after two minutes.

- Choose three areas: studies · work · health · free time · family life.
- Each complaint must use wish; each solution must use a modal or 'it's time'.

Expected output: Three complaint–solution exchanges per role: each complaint uses a correct wish form, each solution a natural modal or 'it's time', and partners swap roles smoothly.

Success criteria

✓ wish forms are accurate (present vs past)
✓ solutions use should / could / it's time naturally
✓ the conversation sounds genuine, not read
✓ both roles complete their turns

Part 6 · The Advanced Upgrade

Intermediate — build accuracy

- Sort your own regrets into present-wishes and past-wishes; say each one aloud.
- Drill: I wish I knew… · I wish I had known… · I wish you would… — one of each, about real life.

Advanced — build flexibility

- Use 'If only…!' for emotion: 'If only he had listened!'
- Use 'wish + would' to complain diplomatically in professional English: 'We were hoping the report would be ready by Friday.'
- Use 'as though nothing had happened' style narrative: 'She greeted me as though we had argued yesterday.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Plan first

Planning (30 seconds): choose one real regret (wish + past perfect), one present situation you would change (wish + past or could), and one piece of advice for a younger learner. Decide the verb forms before you speak.

Speak now — without reading

Speak for one minute: 'My biggest regret — and what it taught me.' Include one wish (past) and one wish (present), then one sentence of advice for a younger learner.

Model response — speak first, then compare; one strong example, not the only answer

I wish I had taken English seriously at school — I lost two years worrying about mistakes instead of speaking. I wish I could explain things as clearly as my teacher could. What it taught me is this: accuracy grows through use. If I were talking to a younger learner now, I'd say record yourself every week and compare the recordings after a month — the progress is real, and you will hear it.

Partner feedback — listen for

✓ wish + past perfect for the regret
✓ wish + past simple (or could) for the present
✓ advice given with an appropriate modal
✓ honest, natural delivery

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Key learning points

- wish + past simple = present wish; wish + past perfect = past regret.
- wish + would = complaint or request about someone else.
- would rather + subject + past = preference about someone else; it's time + past = already late.

Retrieval practice — cover the page, then say

- Say one present wish and one past regret.
- Say a preference about yourself and one about someone else.

Watch out

- 'I wish I have' → 'I wish I had'.

• 'I'd rather you don't' → 'I'd rather you didn't'.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can express a regret and a present wish accurately.

☐ I can use would rather and it's time in real sentences.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 6 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

A. knew hadn't said owned made didn't tell were
B. I wish I had studied harder. I'd rather you didn't smoke here. / I'd rather you didn't smoke. I wish I had more time. It's time we went. reading / watching answers vary

LESSON 7 · COMPARISONS BEYOND THE BASICS

Part 4 — Compare and Persuade | Speaking goal: compare clearly and support comparisons with reasons

Comparison is the engine of persuasion: every opinion is a hidden comparison.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start here — talk first

With a partner, complete the comparison and give one reason:
• Online learning is better than... because...
• The most useful skill I have learned is... because...

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Comparatives and superlatives

Formula

short adj: -er / -est (big → bigger → the biggest)
long adj: more / the most (more interesting → the most interesting)
irregular: good → better → the best · bad → worse → the worst · far → further → the furthest

Use a comparative to compare two people, things or sets. Use a superlative to identify an extreme within a group, which often contains three or more. The exact number is a guide, not a grammatical rule: context and meaning decide.

Examples

This route is shorter than the other one.
This was the most difficult exam I've ever taken.

Remember

Double comparatives are wrong: 'more better' → 'better'. Use 'than', not 'then': 'better than'.

Rule 2 — as … as and patterns of degree

Formula

as + adj + as · not as + adj + as
twice / three times as + adj + as
the + comparative …, the + comparative …
comparative + and + comparative (getting stronger over time)

'as … as' expresses equality; 'the more …, the more …' expresses linked change.

Examples

She's as experienced as her manager.
The more you practise, the more confident you become.
Prices are rising higher and higher.

Remember

'the more … the more …' uses the same comparative structure twice: 'The harder you work, the luckier you get.'

Rule 3 — Comparing with nuance

Formula

far / much / slightly / a little + comparative
by far + superlative · almost as … as · not nearly as … as
compared to / in contrast to + noun

Degree words make comparisons precise — and precision persuades.

Examples

This one is far more reliable.
The results were slightly better than expected.
In contrast to last year, sales have grown.

Remember

When you compare opinions, compare like with like: price with price, quality with quality — then give a reason.

Part 3 · See the Difference

comparative + than vs superlative

Comparative	Superlative	How the meanings differ
This book is better than that one.	This book is the best in the series.	A comparative relates two choices; a superlative identifies an extreme in a group.
It is more expensive than mine.	It is the most expensive option.	Comparison vs top rank.

subtle patterns

Pattern	Look-alike	The difference
The sooner, the better.	Sooner or later...	Linked change vs 'eventually'.
He is as tall as his father.	He is almost as tall as his father.	Equality vs near equality — small words, big difference.

weak vs strong persuasion

Weak: 'X is better than Y.' Strong: 'X is far more reliable than Y because it has been tested for ten years.' A comparison without a reason is an opinion; with a reason it is an argument.

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete or correct the sentences.

1. This route is _____ (short) than the motorway.
2. It was _____ (bad) experience of my life.
3. The _____ (much) you read, the _____ (fast) you learn.
4. She sings _____ (beautiful) than her sister.
5. This phone is not _____ expensive _____ the other one.
6. He is by far the _____ (talented) player in the team.

B. Choose, transform or build.

1. Rewrite with twice as ... as: 'The new laptop costs 2× the old one.'
2. Correct: 'She is more taller than me.'
3. Upgrade the sentence with a degree word: 'This method is better than that one.' (use far + reason)
4. Build a 'the more ... the more' sentence about learning English.
5. Correct: 'This is better then that.'
6. Compare three cities you know. Use a comparative to compare two and a superlative to identify your overall favourite.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Work with a partner

The recommendation game. Each partner prepares a 30-second recommendation (a city, a book, a way to study). Then each defends theirs — comparisons must come with reasons.
• Use at least: one comparative with a degree word, one superlative, one 'as ... as' or 'the more ... the more'.
• After both presentations, agree together on ONE choice.
Expected output: Two 30-second recommendations, each containing at least three accurate comparisons with reasons, followed by one agreed joint choice stated aloud.

Success criteria

✓ comparative and superlative forms are accurate
✓ each comparison has a reason
✓ at least two degree words used (far, slightly, much...)
✓ a joint decision is reached politely

Part 6 · The Advanced Upgrade

Intermediate — build accuracy

• Drill the irregulars: good/better/best, bad/worse/worst, far/further/furthest.
• Practise degree words: far / much / slightly / not nearly — with real comparisons from your life.

Advanced — build flexibility

• Use 'by far', 'the single most…', 'the least likely to…' for confident evaluation.
• Use concessive comparison: 'Although X is cheaper, Y is far better value in the long run.'
• Use 'compared with / in contrast to' to frame data like an academic: 'Compared with 2020, participation has doubled.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Plan first

Planning (30 seconds): choose your position, then prepare three comparisons — one with a degree word (far, much, slightly), one superlative, and one 'the more …' or 'as … as' pattern. Give each one a short reason.

Speak now — without reading

Persuasion talk (one minute): argue for ONE of these — 'The best age to learn a language' / 'The best way to prepare for the TOEFL' / 'The best investment of one hour a day'. Use at least three comparisons.

Model response — speak first, then compare; one strong example, not the only answer

The best age to start learning a language is early childhood — children pick up pronunciation far more easily than adults, and they are much less afraid of mistakes. The best use of one hour a day, however, is deliberate speaking practice: it is twice as effective as passive review because you get instant feedback. Compared with grammar drills alone, conversation is by far the most useful investment. The more you speak, the more natural your grammar becomes.

Partner feedback — listen for

✓ accurate comparative and superlative forms
✓ reasons support the comparisons
✓ degree words add precision (far, slightly, by far…)
✓ the conclusion states a clear choice

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Key learning points

• Comparatives compare two choices; superlatives identify an extreme within a group; 'as … as' shows equality.
• 'the + comparative, the + comparative' shows linked change.
• Persuasive comparisons come with reasons and precise degree words.

Retrieval practice — cover the page, then say

• Say one comparison with 'far', one with 'the more…the more'.
• Rank three things in your life with superlatives and explain why.

Watch out

• 'more better' → 'better'; 'then' → 'than'.
• Don't compare unlike things: price with price, quality with quality.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can compare with precise forms and degree words.

☐ My comparisons are supported by reasons.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 7 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

A. shorter the worst more / faster more beautifully as / as most talented
B. The new laptop is twice as expensive as the old one. She is taller than me. This method is far better than that one because it saves time. (answers vary) answers vary This is better than that. answers vary

LESSON 8 · LINKING IDEAS AND BUILDING ARGUMENTS

Part 4 — Compare and Persuade | Speaking goal: organise opinions into coherent, well-linked spoken arguments

Grammar connects sentences; linkers connect thoughts. This lesson is about being easy to follow.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start here — talk first

Speak for 30 seconds about: 'Why people learn English.' Then listen to your partner. How many different linking words did you each use?

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Contrast and concession

Formula

although / even though + subject + verb (full clause)
despite / in spite of + noun or -ing (no subject + verb!)
however / nevertheless / on the other hand (start a new sentence)

'although' joins two clauses; 'despite' joins a noun phrase. Mixing them is the most common error in this area.

Examples

Although it was raining, we went out.
Despite the rain, we went out.
The plan was risky. Nevertheless, we agreed to it.

Remember

'despite of' does not exist. → 'despite' or 'in spite of'.

Rule 2 — Cause, result and purpose

Formula

because / since / as + clause
because of / due to / owing to + noun
therefore / consequently / as a result (result)
so that / in order to + base verb (purpose)

Notice the two families: + clause (because) vs + noun (because of).

Examples

We cancelled because of the storm.
The storm was severe; therefore, we cancelled.
She left early so that she could catch the train.

Remember

'due to' is best with a noun: 'due to the delay'.

Rule 3 — Building an argument you can say out loud

Formula

POINT → REASON → EXAMPLE → LINK to the listener
Opinion: I believe that … · Reason: This is because … · Example: For instance …
Addition: moreover / what is more / another point is that …

A spoken argument needs a skeleton. Use the same shape every time until it becomes automatic.

Examples

I believe online learning is effective. This is because it allows flexible scheduling. For instance, last year I studied at night after work. Moreover, it is often more affordable.

Remember

Spoken arguments are short. Three well-linked points beat eight unlinked ones.

Rule 4 — Ordering and summarising

Formula
Firstly … · Secondly … · Finally …
In short · To sum up · All in all · In conclusion

Signposting tells the listener where you are going — it reduces effort and increases influence.

Examples
To sum up, the advantages clearly outweigh the costs.
All in all, I would recommend the second option.

Remember
End an argument with a summary sentence — listeners remember the end.

Part 3 · See the Difference

although / despite / however

although + clause	despite + noun/-ing	however = new sentence	The rule
Although it was late, we continued.	Despite the late hour, we continued.	It was late; however, we continued.	One idea, three packages: + clause / + noun / separate sentence.

because vs because of

because + clause	because of + noun	Why
Because I was tired, I stopped.	Because of my tiredness, I stopped.	because + clause · because of + noun. A small word changes the whole grammar.

while / whereas / although

'while' and 'whereas' contrast two equal facts: 'I like tea, whereas she prefers coffee.' 'although' concedes one point against another: 'Although I like tea, I ordered coffee.'

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete or correct the sentences.

1. _____ the heavy traffic, we arrived on time. (Despite / Although)
2. _____ being very tired, she finished the report. (Despite / Although)
3. He failed the exam; _____, he did not give up. (however / despite)
4. We left early _____ we could avoid the traffic. (so that / because of)
5. The flight was cancelled. _____, all hotels were full. (As a result / Although)
6. I enjoy city life, _____ my wife prefers the countryside. (whereas / despite)

B. Choose, transform or build.

1. Combine with although: 'The task was difficult. Everyone finished.'
2. Combine with despite + -ing: 'She was not selected. She applied again.'
3. Correct: 'Despite of the cost, we decided to proceed.'
4. Build an argument skeleton (point → reason → example) for: 'Reading improves speaking.'
5. Correct: 'Although the cost, we bought it.'
6. Add a summary opener to close: give two opinions about technology in education.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Work with a partner

Mini-debate. Choose a position together by arguing against each other — politely — then swap positions and argue the other side.

• Topic: 'Homework should be replaced by daily speaking practice.'
• Each person must use at least: one although/despite, one cause linker, one result linker, and one summary opener.

Expected output: One two-minute mini-debate per role: a clear point with reason and example, one answer to the other side, and a closing summary — followed by a one-sentence verdict you both accept.

Success criteria

✓ linkers are accurate (especially despite + noun)
✓ argument has point → reason → example
✓ the other side is answered (counterargument)
✓ the closing summary is clear

Part 6 · The Advanced Upgrade

Intermediate — build accuracy

• Sort linkers by job: contrast (although, despite, however) · cause (because, due to) · result (therefore, as a result) · addition (moreover).
• Drill the pairs: although + clause / despite + noun — five real situations.

Advanced — build flexibility

• Use 'Not only … but also …' with inversion in formal speech: 'Not only did she apologise, but she also offered a refund.'
• Use concessive balance: 'It is true that …; nevertheless, …' · 'Admittedly, …; even so, …'
• Use 'which' to comment on a whole clause: 'She apologised publicly, which changed the whole mood.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Plan first

Planning (45 seconds): write only four keywords — claim, two reasons, concession. Choose your linkers before you speak (although / because / therefore / to sum up), and leave the example to improvise.

Speak now — without reading

Opinion talk (90 seconds): 'What makes a good teacher?' Structure: opinion → two reasons with examples → one concession → summary. Speak without notes.

Model response — speak first, then compare; one strong example, not the only answer

I believe what makes a good teacher is clear feedback. This is because learners improve fastest when they know exactly what to fix. For instance, my first English teacher corrected our pronunciation every day, and within a month our class sounded noticeably better. Although games and fun activities help people relax, I would trade them for precise correction any day. To sum up: a good teacher makes the next step obvious.

Partner feedback — listen for

✓ point → reason → example structure is visible
✓ contrast and concession used accurately (although / despite)
✓ cause and result linkers present
✓ summary closes the talk clearly

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Key learning points

• although + clause; despite + noun/-ing; however starts a new sentence.
• because + clause; because of + noun; therefore / as a result show consequence.
• Spoken arguments follow: point → reason → example → summary.

Retrieval practice — cover the page, then say

• Give a 20-second argument using exactly three linkers.
• Say the same contrast idea with although, despite and however.

Watch out

• 'despite of' → 'despite' / 'in spite of'.
• 'Although the cost…' → 'Despite the cost…' or 'Although it was costly…'

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can link ideas with the right linker family.

☐ My argument has a clear skeleton and a summary.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 8 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

A. Despite Despite (not 'although' — it needs a clause: Although she was very tired) however so that As a result whereas
B. Although the task was difficult, everyone finished. Despite not being selected, she applied again. / Despite the rejection, she applied again. Despite the cost, we decided to proceed. answers vary — must include point, reason, example Despite the cost, we bought it. / Although it was costly, we bought it. answers vary — must open with To sum up / All in all / In conclusion

REVIEW TEST 2

Cumulative review — Lessons 1–8 · 15 questions · suggested time: 20 minutes

Part A — Complete the sentences.

1. If I _____ (know) his number, I would call him now.
2. I wish I _____ (take) that opportunity last year.
3. This method is _____ (effective) than the old one.
4. While I _____ (read — ongoing action), the lights went out.
5. When we arrived, the guests _____ (already / leave).
6. It's high time we _____ (make) a decision.
7. This option is by far the _____ (good) for our budget.
8. Unless you _____ (hurry), you'll miss the bus.

Part B — Rewrite, combine or transform.

1. Combine with despite: 'The exam was hard. Everyone passed.'
2. Rewrite as a second conditional: 'I don't have a car, so I can't drive you.'
3. Give polite advice to a friend who wants to quit their job without a plan. (2 modals)
4. Make it polite: 'Where is the bank?'

Part C — Use and communication.

1. Rewrite as a mixed conditional (past → present): 'She didn't save money, so she can't buy the car now.'
2. Compare with a reason: 'This course is better than that one.' (use far + reason)
3. Correct: 'Despite of the cost, we decided to proceed.'

When you finish, check your work in Appendix 5. The answers are kept separate so you can complete the test without seeing them.

LESSON 9 · PASSIVE VOICE IN NATURAL ENGLISH

Part 5 — Describe and Explain | Speaking goal: choose between active and passive for the right focus

The passive is not a fancy extra — it is how English focuses on what matters.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start here — talk first

Look at these two sentences. Which sounds like news, and which sounds like a story?
• Someone stole my bicycle yesterday.
• My bicycle was stolen yesterday.
Tell your partner about something that happened to you — once with the active, once with the passive. Which version focuses on the result?

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — How the passive is built

Formula

be + past participle (the tense lives in 'be')
Present: is/are done · Past: was/were done
Future: will be done · Perfect: has/have been done
Modals: can/must/should be done

To make a passive, change the object of an active sentence into the subject, and put the verb into 'be + participle'.

Examples

They clean the office every day. → The office is cleaned every day.
They will announce the results tomorrow. → The results will be announced tomorrow.

Remember

Add the agent with 'by' only when it matters: 'The novel was written by Atiq Rahimi.'

Rule 2 — When to use the passive

Formula

Use the passive when: the result matters more · the doer is unknown, obvious, or general ('people', 'they') · you want objective or formal tone

News, reports, research and professional communication often use the passive to focus on events or processes. The agent may be left out when it is unknown or unimportant, or included in a by-phrase when it matters.

Examples

Mistakes were made in the report. (polite — no blame)
The vaccine is being tested in several countries.
The meeting has been postponed until Monday.

Remember

In everyday stories about yourself, the active is usually better: 'I broke my phone' (clearer than 'my phone was broken by me').

Rule 3 — Reporting verbs and passive patterns

Formula

It is said / believed / thought that …
He is said to be / to have been …
have/get something done (see Lesson 10)

These patterns sound objective and educated — very useful in formal speaking.

Examples

It is widely believed that reading improves writing.
She is said to speak five languages.

Remember
'It is said that he left' = 'He is said to have left.' (the leaving is earlier).

Part 3 · See the Difference

active vs passive: what changes?

Active	Passive	Why
Someone attacked the man.	The man was attacked.	The passive can omit the agent — the event or result takes focus. Add a by-phrase if the agent matters.
The committee approved the plan.	The plan was approved.	Formal and objective: the decision matters, not the committee.

get-passive vs be-passive

'get' + participle is more informal and often emotional or unexpected: 'He got fired.' Compare 'He was dismissed.' (formal). 'Get' is common in speech: 'They got married last year.'

false passives

Some verbs look passive but are not: 'The book sold well.' · 'The door opened.' These describe how something happened, not an action done to it.

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete or correct the sentences.

1. The bridge _____ (build) in 2019.
2. The results _____ (announce) tomorrow.
3. This room _____ (clean) every morning.
4. My wallet _____ (steal) on the bus yesterday.
5. A new policy _____ (just / introduce).
6. The letters must _____ (send) before noon.

B. Choose, transform or build.

1. Rewrite in the passive: 'Someone has stolen my bicycle.'
2. Rewrite in the active: 'The decision was made by the board.'
3. Rewrite formally: 'People say that he is the best candidate.'
4. Correct: 'The house was builted in 1990.'
5. Correct: 'My phone was stolen by me.' (make it natural)
6. Report the news with a passive: 'They will close the road tomorrow.'

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Work with a partner

The newsroom. Each partner is a reporter. Describe three events from yesterday (local, personal or world news) using the passive. The editor (partner) asks: who did it?
• Events: an accident · a new opening · a rule change · a sports result · something at work or school.
• Use at least two passives and one reporting structure (It is said / It is believed).
Expected output: Three news items per reporter in report-style speech, with two accurate passives and one reporting structure, surviving the editor's 'who did it?' question.

Success criteria

✓ passive forms are accurate across tenses
✓ the agent is given only when it matters
✓ tone is objective and report-like
✓ the editor's questions get clear answers

Part 6 · The Advanced Upgrade

Intermediate — build accuracy

• Drill passive formation in four tenses: present, past, future, perfect — with objects from your daily life.
• Learn the reporting pair: 'It is said that…' / 'He is said to…' — three real examples.

Advanced — build flexibility

• Use the passive with 'get' for informal emotional colour: 'He got promoted after only six months.'
• Use 'It is claimed / alleged / assumed that…' in formal discussion.
• Use passive + participle clauses in writing-style speech: 'Founded in 1971, the school now teaches over a thousand students.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Plan first

Planning (30 seconds): pick three real events from this week — two that affect people rather than doers, one you want to comment on. Fix the tense of each passive (is/are, was/were, will be, has been).

Speak now — without reading

Ninety-second news brief: report three things that happened this week (in your city, your work or your studies). Use the passive for events and one reporting structure. Finish with one comment in the active voice.

Model response — speak first, then compare; one strong example, not the only answer

Three things happened this week. A new footbridge was opened near the school, so traffic has been diverted along the main road. It is said that the council will publish the survey results on Friday, and two main streets were cleaned every night last week. My own view is simple: the council should publish the data openly — that is the first thing I would ask for.

Partner feedback — listen for

✓ at least three accurate passive structures
✓ objective reporting tone
✓ agent mentioned only when important
✓ clear final comment (active voice)

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Key learning points

• Passive = be + past participle; the tense lives in 'be'.
• Use the passive for results, unknown/obvious doers, and objective tone.
• 'It is said that…' = 'He is said to…' — both are formal and natural.

Retrieval practice — cover the page, then say

• Put three objects from your room into passive sentences (different tenses).
• Say one formal reporting sentence about a person you know.

Watch out

• 'was builted' → 'was built'.
• Don't use the passive for your own story if the active is clearer: 'I lost my keys' is better than 'my keys were lost by me'.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can form the passive in four tenses.

☐ I choose active or passive for the right focus.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 9 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

A. was built will be announced is cleaned was stolen has just been introduced be sent
B. My bicycle has been stolen. The board made the decision. It is said that he is the best candidate. / He is said to be the best candidate. The house was built in 1990. I lost my phone. / I had my phone stolen. (answers vary) The road will be closed tomorrow.

LESSON 10 · CAUSATIVE STRUCTURES

Part 5 — Describe and Explain | Speaking goal: talk about services, arrangements, influence and responsibility naturally

English has a special grammar for 'I arranged it — someone else did it'. This is it.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start here — talk first

Talk with a partner: what do people usually 'have done' in your city?
• haircuts · repairs · cleaning · deliveries · tailoring
Which do you do yourself, and which do you pay others for? Why?

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — have/get something done

Formula

have + object + past participle → arrange for someone to do it
get + object + past participle → the same meaning, more informal
Negative/question: I haven't had it done · Did you get it fixed?

Use this when you arrange or pay for a service. The doer is unimportant or obvious (a professional, a shop, a technician).

Examples

I had my car serviced last week.
She's getting her house painted this month.
We need to have the documents translated.

Remember

This structure often appears in stories about problems: 'I had my phone stolen on the bus.' (something happened to my possession — not a service I ordered!)

Rule 2 — make, let, have, get + person + verb

Formula

make + person + base verb → force (no choice)
let + person + base verb → allow (no 'to')
have + person + base verb → instruct/arrange (informal)
get + person + to + base verb → persuade (with 'to'!)

These four verbs control other people's actions — with different levels of force.

Examples

The teacher made us rewrite the essay.
My parents let me travel alone when I was sixteen.
I'll have my assistant call you.
I finally got my brother to help me.

Remember

'get' is the only one with 'to': 'get someone to do something'.

Rule 3 — Talking about services and arrangements

Formula

I need to have my… done · I'm having my… done on Tuesday
How much do you charge to…? · Could you … for me?
I get my… done at… (regular arrangement)

These chunks are the real-life service English: shops, clinics, offices, travel.

Examples

I get my hair cut at the same place every month.
I'm having my laptop repaired — I hope it's ready by Friday.

Remember

For one action by one person that you do yourself or that isn't a service, use the normal active: 'I fixed my laptop' — not 'I had my laptop fixed' (unless you arranged it).

Part 3 · See the Difference

service vs accident

Service I ordered	Accident that happened	Why
I had my car washed.	I had my car damaged in the storm.	Same grammar, different world: one is a service I ordered; the other is something that happened to me.

causative verbs compared

make — force	let — allow	have — instruct	get — persuade	The relationship
She made me apologise.	She let me leave.	She had me rewrite it.	She got me to help her.	force → allow → instruct → persuade. The grammar tells you the relationship.

make vs let in passives

'make' keeps 'to' when it becomes passive: 'I was made to wait an hour.' But 'let' does not: 'They let me go' → 'I was allowed to go' (we usually avoid 'I was let go' except in fixed expressions).

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete or correct the sentences.

1. I need to have my suit _____ (alter) before the wedding.
2. When did you last get your hair _____ (cut)?
3. The noise made me _____ (lose) my concentration.
4. They let us _____ (use) the kitchen.
5. I'm having my eyes _____ (test) on Thursday.
6. She finally got her son _____ (eat) the vegetables.

B. Choose, transform or build.

1. Rewrite with have: 'I paid someone to service my car.'
2. Rewrite with get (persuasion): 'After much discussion, my friend agreed to drive us.'
3. Correct: 'I will get my car to repair tomorrow.'
4. Correct: 'She made me to wait outside.'
5. Describe something you had done recently (service or accident — say which).
6. Ask politely at a shop: you need your phone screen replaced (causative question).

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Work with a partner

The service conversation. Partner A runs a repair shop / salon / clinic; Partner B has problems with their possessions (car, hair, laptop, phone). Negotiate what will be done, when, and for how much — using causatives throughout.
• Partner B: describe at least three things that need doing (need to have… done).
• Partner A: explain what you will do (I'll have… done), what the customer should do, and the price. Use make/let/get at least once.
Expected output: One completed service negotiation per pair: at least three things that need doing, a price and a time agreed, and one make/let/get sentence used accurately.

Success criteria

✓ causative forms are accurate (have/get + object + participle)
✓ service language sounds natural
✓ prices and times are agreed
✓ the conversation includes influence language (make/let/get)

Part 6 · The Advanced Upgrade

Intermediate — build accuracy

• Drill the four causatives: make / let / have / get — one true sentence each about people you know.
• Practise the service chunks: 'I need to have my... done.' · 'When can you have it ready?'

Advanced — build flexibility

• Use 'have someone do' for professional delegation: 'I'll have the team look into it.'
• Use experience-causatives in narrative: 'He had us all laughing for an hour.' · 'The film had me thinking for days.'
• Use 'get round to + -ing' and 'end up + -ing': 'I finally got round to having the flat painted.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Plan first

Planning (30 seconds): choose a real or invented bad day. Plan three moments — one service you arranged (had something done), one accident (had something happen to me), and one make/let/get moment.

Speak now — without reading

Story challenge (one minute): 'A day when everything went wrong.' Use at least two causatives (including 'had something done' or 'had something happen to me'), and explain what you made, let or got someone to do afterwards.

Model response — speak first, then compare; one strong example, not the only answer

Last Friday started badly. I had my car serviced the evening before, but it still wouldn't start, so I let my neighbour try the battery — he is a mechanic. Then the courier delivered my laptop to the wrong company, and I had to wait while it was forwarded. My manager made me postpone the presentation until the afternoon, and I finally got my brother to drive me to work. By the evening the whole day had me laughing — what a mess!

Partner feedback — listen for

✓ causative structures used accurately
✓ clear distinction between service and accident
✓ story is easy to follow
✓ at least one make/let/get structure

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Key learning points

• have/get + object + participle = arrange a service (or: something happened to me).
• make = force; let = allow; have = instruct; get = persuade (get + to + verb).
• The passive of 'make' keeps 'to': 'I was made to wait.'

Retrieval practice — cover the page, then say

• Say three things you would like to have done this month.
• Describe one person who made you do something and one who let you do something.

Watch out

• 'get my car to repair' → 'get my car repaired'.
• 'made me to wait' → 'made me wait'.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can arrange services with have/get causatives.

☐ I can express force, permission, instruction and persuasion correctly.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 10 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

A. altered cut lose use tested to eat
B. I had my car serviced. I got my friend to drive us. / After much discussion, I got my friend to drive. I will get my car repaired tomorrow. She made me wait outside. answers vary Could you have my phone screen replaced? / How much would it cost to have my screen replaced?

LESSON 11 · GERUNDS AND INFINITIVES

Part 6 — Speak with Greater Precision | Speaking goal: choose the right verb pattern for your meaning

Some verbs want -ing after them; some want 'to'. Getting this right marks you as advanced.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start here — talk first

Finish the sentences — then compare with your partner:
• I enjoy... · I hope... · I avoid... · I decided...
Which verbs feel natural with -ing? Which with 'to'? You already know more than you think.

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Verbs that take the gerund (-ing)

Formula

enjoy · avoid · consider · finish · keep · mind · miss · practise · suggest · give up · feel like · can't help + verb-ing

These verbs talk about experiences, reactions and activities as things.

Examples

I enjoy reading before bed.
He avoided making eye contact.
Would you mind opening the window?

Remember

When a verb follows mind directly, use -ing: 'Do you mind waiting?' Other patterns exist, such as 'Would you mind if I opened the window?'

Rule 2 — Verbs that take the infinitive (to + verb)

Formula

agree · decide · hope · intend · learn · manage · offer · plan · promise · refuse · seem · tend · want · would like + to + base verb

These verbs look forward — to intentions, decisions and attempts.

Examples

She decided to change careers.
We plan to visit next spring.
He seems to know everyone.

Remember

'would like to...' is polite desire: 'I'd like to ask a question.'

Rule 3 — Verbs that change meaning

Formula

remember / forget / regret / stop / try / go on / mean
+ -ing → the earlier action · + to → the later action (or purpose)

With these verbs, the pattern is not decoration — it changes the meaning.

Examples

I remember locking the door. (I did it; I recall that)
Remember to lock the door. (don't forget — it comes later)
He stopped smoking. (he quit)
He stopped to smoke. (he paused his walk for a cigarette)
I tried restarting the laptop. (a method)
I tried to open the window. (an attempt)

Remember

'I mean to do it' = I intend to. 'Missing the bus means walking' = results in.

Rule 4 — Gerund as subject and after prepositions

Formula

Verb-ing + ... = the activity as a subject
Preposition + verb-ing (about doing · instead of going · before leaving · good at speaking)

A gerund can be a subject: 'Swimming keeps me fit.' After any preposition, use -ing.

Examples

Learning a language takes patience.
She left without saying goodbye.
I'm interested in improving my pronunciation.

Remember

'to' is a preposition in some phrases: look forward to · be used to · object to · devote ... to · when it comes to. All take -ing: 'I look forward to hearing from you.'

Part 3 · See the Difference

meaning-changing pairs

+ -ing (earlier action)	+ to (later action)	The difference
I stopped eating sugar.	I stopped to eat something.	quit an activity vs pause an activity for another
I remembered to call her.	I remembered calling her.	did it because I recalled (to) vs recalled the action (-ing)
He tried to move the table.	He tried moving the table.	attempt (to) vs experiment/method (-ing)

need + -ing vs need + to

'The car needs washing.' = 'The car needs to be washed.' The gerund here is passive in meaning. Also: 'My hair needs cutting.'

with prepositions: always -ing

Common traps: 'interested in learning' (not 'in learn') · 'good at explaining' · 'instead of complaining' · 'before leaving' · 'after finishing'.

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete or correct the sentences.

1. Would you mind _____ (help) me with this?
2. She avoided _____ (answer) the question.
3. We decided _____ (accept) the offer.
4. I look forward to _____ (hear) from you.
5. He stopped _____ (smoke) last year.
6. She tried _____ (open) the window, but it was stuck. (an attempt)

B. Choose, transform or build.

1. Correct: 'I enjoy to read novels.'
2. Correct: 'I look forward to meet you.'
3. Correct: 'She suggested to go early.'
4. Rewrite with need: 'The room must be cleaned.'
5. Choose and explain: I remembered (posting / to post) the letter. (I want to say: I recall doing it)
6. Make a sentence with 'Instead of...' + -ing about study habits.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Work with a partner

The habits interview. Ask each other about routines, plans and preferences — using gerund and infinitive patterns in every question and answer.

• Questions to adapt: What do you enjoy doing at weekends? What have you decided to change this year? What do you avoid doing? What are you looking forward to?

• Each person must use at least four different gerund/infinitive verbs.

Expected output: A five-question interview per role: each person answers with at least four different gerund/infinitive patterns and asks two follow-up questions.

Success criteria

✓ patterns are accurate (-ing vs to)
✓ at least one meaning-changing verb used correctly
✓ conversation flows naturally
✓ follow-up questions asked

Part 6 · The Advanced Upgrade

Intermediate — build accuracy

• Learn in chunks, not lists: 'I enjoy swimming' · 'I decided to leave' — five chunks a day.
• Drill the meaning pairs: stop/remember/try — with real examples from your week.

Advanced — build flexibility

• Use complex subjects: 'Finding time to practise is harder than finding motivation.'
• Use 'there is no point in + -ing' · 'it's worth + -ing' · 'it's a waste of time + -ing'.
• Use 'have difficulty (in) + -ing': 'I had difficulty understanding the accent.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Plan first

Planning (30 seconds): list three activities you enjoy or avoid (-ing) and two plans or decisions (to + verb). Mark one meaning-changing verb — stop, remember or try — to use in both patterns if you can.

Speak now — without reading

Speak for one minute: 'What learning English has taught me about myself.' Use at least three gerunds and two infinitives. End with one decision you have made (to + verb).

Model response — speak first, then compare; one strong example, not the only answer

Learning English has taught me to be patient with myself. I enjoy reading in English now, and at first I tried translating every word — that only slowed me down, so I stopped doing it and started guessing from context. I keep a short vocabulary journal every evening because writing helps me notice patterns. I used to avoid speaking because I feared mistakes, so I've decided to join an evening class this winter and speak with real people.

Partner feedback — listen for

✓ gerund and infinitive patterns accurate
✓ at least one meaning-changing verb used correctly
✓ sentences are connected, not listed
✓ the final decision is clear

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Key learning points

• Some verbs take -ing, some take 'to', some take both with meaning changes.
• After any preposition, use -ing — including 'to' in look forward to, be used to.
• Gerunds work as subjects: 'Practising daily helps.'

Retrieval practice — cover the page, then say

• Say two sentences with 'stop' (both meanings) and two with 'try' (both meanings).
• Name five verbs + -ing and five verbs + to from memory.

Watch out

• 'enjoy to read' → 'enjoy reading'.

• 'look forward to meet' → 'look forward to meeting'.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can choose the pattern automatically with common verbs.

☐ I know the meaning-changing pairs.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 11 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

A. helping answering to accept hearing smoking to open
B. I enjoy reading novels. I look forward to meeting you. She suggested going early. The room needs cleaning. / The room needs to be cleaned. posting answers vary

LESSON 12 · RELATIVE CLAUSES AND CONCISE DESCRIPTIONS

Part 6 — Speak with Greater Precision | Speaking goal: describe people, places and ideas precisely in one sentence

Relative clauses let you build two ideas into one clean sentence — the mark of fluent speech.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start here — talk first

Describe without naming: choose someone in the class, a famous person or a place — describe it so your partner can guess. Use 'who', 'which' or 'that' in every sentence.

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Defining relative clauses (essential information)

Formula

who (people) · which (things) · that (both) · whose (possession) · where · when
No commas. Without the clause, the sentence changes meaning.
Object pronouns can be omitted: 'The book (that) I read…'

A defining clause tells us WHICH one. It is part of the meaning, so no commas.

Examples

The woman who called you is my manager.
The town where I grew up has changed a lot.
The man whose car was damaged is waiting outside.

Remember

In speech, drop the object 'that/who/which' when it is the object: 'The film we watched…' (not 'The film which we watched it…').

Rule 2 — Non-defining relative clauses (extra information)

Formula

, who … , / , which … , (commas — like a quiet aside)
Never use 'that' here. Never drop the pronoun.

A non-defining clause adds information about something already identified. It is spoken with a small pause.

Examples

My brother, who lives in Dubai, is visiting next week.
The project, which took six months, was finally approved.

Remember

With commas, the clause can comment on the whole sentence: 'She apologised publicly, which changed the mood.'

Rule 3 — Prepositions in relative clauses

Formula

… the clinic to which I go … (formal)
… the clinic which I go to … (normal)
… the clinic I go to … (speech)

In formal English the preposition moves before the pronoun; in speech it stays at the end.

Examples

The colleague with whom I worked has retired. (formal)
The colleague I worked with has retired. (natural)

Remember

For people after prepositions, use 'whom' in formal English: 'the person to whom I spoke.'

Rule 4 — Reduced clauses: the concision tool

Formula

who is / who was + … → (drop 'who is'): 'The man (who is) standing there…'
which was + participle → 'The results (which were) published today…'

Dropping 'who is/which was' makes descriptions tighter — very useful in speech and reports.

Examples

Anyone wishing to attend must register. (= who wishes)
The documents attached to this email... (= which are attached)

Remember

Only drop 'who is/which was' — never drop a full verb: 'The man who called' cannot become 'The man called'.

Part 3 · See the Difference

defining vs non-defining

Defining (no commas)	Non-defining (commas)	Why
My sister who lives in London is a doctor. (I have several sisters)	My sister, who lives in London, is a doctor. (I have one sister)	The commas change how much we learn: identification vs extra detail.
Students who pass the exam receive a certificate.	My cousin, who passed the exam, received a certificate.	No commas when the clause defines which ones.

that vs which vs who

that (speech, things/people)	which (things)	who (people)	The rule
The book that I bought...	The book which I bought...	The man who helped me...	that is common for things and people in speech; which/who after commas; 'that' never after commas.

whose vs of whom

'The student whose essay won the prize...' is natural in speech; 'the student the essay of whom won...' is possible but clumsy. Prefer 'whose'.

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete or correct the sentences.

1. The girl _____ helped me was kind. (who / which / whose)
2. My phone, _____ I bought last year, has already broken. (that / which)
3. This is the café _____ we first met. (where / which)
4. The man _____ car was stolen is the manager. (who / whose)
5. The results _____ were announced today are surprising. (reduced clause: leave a gap or use which)
6. I read the article you recommended. (insert the omitted pronoun — what is it?)

B. Choose, transform or build.

1. Combine: 'The teacher is excellent. She taught me last year.' (use who)
2. Combine with commas: 'My friend is a pilot. He travels constantly.' (extra information)
3. Correct: 'My mother, that lives in Kandahar, is visiting.'
4. Correct: 'The book what I read was amazing.'
5. Reduce: 'Students who are interested in the course should apply.'
6. Describe your favourite place using one defining and one non-defining clause.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Work with a partner

The guessing game. Describe a person, place or object from your life using only relative clauses — never name it. Partner guesses, then swaps.

- Each person describes two items, using at least one defining and one non-defining clause.
- After guessing, improve each other's sentences: make them more concise.

Expected output: Two successful guesses per pair: each description contains one defining and one non-defining clause, and both partners leave with one improved, more concise sentence.

Success criteria

✓ relative pronouns chosen correctly (who/which/whose/where)
✓ defining vs non-defining punctuation/meaning respected
✓ descriptions are concise and clear
✓ partner can guess the item

Part 6 · The Advanced Upgrade

Intermediate — build accuracy

- Drill the four pronouns: who / which / whose / where — with people and places from your life.
- Practise dropping object pronouns: 'The film we saw…' · 'The course I chose…'

Advanced — build flexibility

- Use 'which' to comment on a whole clause: 'He apologised, which surprised everyone.'
- Use cleft focus with 'what': 'What I need is time.' · 'What surprised me was the result.'
- Use reduced clauses in formal speech: 'Anyone arriving late will be asked to wait.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Plan first

Planning (30 seconds): choose the person, then note three roles — who they are (defining), one extra detail with commas (non-defining), and one -ing description (reduced). Decide which clause identifies and which one comments.

Speak now — without reading

Describe-and-explain talk (one minute): talk about a person who influenced you. Use two defining clauses, one non-defining clause, and one reduced clause. Do not write anything.

Model response — speak first, then compare; one strong example, not the only answer

The person who influenced me most is my uncle, who taught physics for thirty years. He is the man whose advice I still hear when I sit down to study: start with the hardest task. The teacher who encouraged me at school lent me books written by Afghan authors, and the colleague sitting beside me at my first job showed me how to admit a mistake quickly. Anyone working with him learns the same thing — preparation beats talent.

Partner feedback — listen for

✓ relative clauses are accurate and natural
✓ at least one non-defining clause with correct meaning
✓ one concise reduced form
✓ the person's influence is explained clearly

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Key learning points

- Defining clauses identify (no commas); non-defining clauses add detail (commas).
- Drop object pronouns in speech: 'The book I read…'.
- Reduced clauses ('who is' dropped) make descriptions concise.

Retrieval practice — cover the page, then say

- Say one defining and one non-defining clause about people near you.
- Describe your city with two relative clauses and one reduced clause.

Watch out

- 'the book what I read' → 'the book (that) I read'.
- 'My mother, that lives…' → 'My mother, who lives…'

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I choose the right pronoun and punctuation automatically.

☐ I can compress descriptions with reduced clauses.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 12 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

A. who which where whose (that) were / which were — or simply 'announced today' with 'The results announced today…' that (or which)
B. The teacher who taught me last year is excellent. My friend, who is a pilot, travels constantly. My mother, who lives in Kandahar, is visiting. The book (that) I read was amazing. Students interested in the course should apply. answers vary

REVIEW TEST 3

Cumulative review — Lessons 1–12 · 15 questions · suggested time: 20 minutes

Part A — Complete the sentences.

1. The house _____ (build) in the 1960s.
2. I had my watch _____ (repair) last week.
3. She is said _____ (speak) five languages.
4. He avoided _____ (make) the same mistake twice.
5. This is the café _____ we first met.
6. She is the teacher _____ class inspired me. (who / whose)
7. I'd rather you _____ (not/mention) this to anyone.
8. He talks as if he _____ (know) everything.

Part B — Rewrite, combine or transform.

1. Rewrite with need: 'The room must be cleaned.'
2. Rewrite as a deduction (past): 'Perhaps he missed the train.'
3. Reduce: 'Students who are interested in the course should apply.'
4. Make it formal and passive: 'People believe that the economy is improving.'

Part C — Use and communication.

1. Complete: The _____ (much) you practise, the _____ (confident) you become.
2. Correct the indirect question: 'Do you know where is the bank?'
3. Complete the causative: I _____ my hair cut yesterday.
4. Correct: 'I enjoy to read novels.'

When you finish, check your work in Appendix 5. The answers are kept separate so you can complete the test without seeing them.

LESSON 13 · REPORTED SPEECH AND REPORTING VERBS

Part 7 — Sound More Natural and Advanced | Speaking goal: report conversations and summarise information accurately and naturally

Half of real speaking is reporting what other people said. This lesson makes that effortless.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start here — talk first

Tell your partner: what did a friend or family member say to you this week? Report the words — don't read them. What exactly did they say?

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — The backshift: one step back in time

Formula

Direct: 'I am tired.' → She said (that) she was tired.
Present simple → past simple · Present continuous → past continuous
Past simple → past perfect · will → would · can → could · may → might
would / could / should / past perfect → stay the same

When you report, the verbs usually step back one tense. 'That' is optional and often dropped in speech.

Examples

"I work here." → He said he worked there.
"I've finished." → She said she had finished.
"I'll call you." → He said he would call me.

Remember

If the statement is still true, you may keep the original tense: 'She said the earth goes round the sun.'

Rule 2 — Reporting questions and commands

Formula

Yes/No question: ask + if / whether + subject + verb (statement order!)
Wh- question: ask + question word + subject + verb
Command: tell / ask / order + person + to + base verb
Negative command: told me not to + base verb

Reported questions use statement word order — no auxiliary 'do', no question mark.

Examples

"Where do you live?" → She asked me where I lived.
"Are you ready?" → He asked if I was ready.
"Sit down." → She told me to sit down.
"Don't worry." → He told me not to worry.

Remember

'say' has no object: 'He said that…' · 'tell' needs a person: 'He told me that…' (never 'He said me…').

Rule 3 — Reporting verbs: beyond say and tell

Formula

admit · agree · apologise · argue · claim · complain · explain · insist · mention · promise · refuse · remind · suggest · warn
Patterns: verb + that … · verb + to + verb · verb + person + to + verb · verb + -ing

Reporting verbs make summaries compact and precise — exactly what the TOEFL and professional English require.

Examples

He admitted making a mistake. (verb + -ing)
She promised to call back. (verb + to)
The doctor warned me not to travel. (verb + person + to)
He suggested leaving early. (verb + -ing)

Remember
'suggest' takes -ing or 'that': 'She suggested going' / 'She suggested that we go' (not 'suggested me to go').

Rule 4 — Time and place references

Formula
now → then · today → that day · yesterday → the day before
tomorrow → the next day / the following day · last week → the week before
here → there · this → that · ago → before

When you report later, shift the time words too — or the story makes no sense.

Examples
"I'll do it tomorrow." → She said she would do it the next day.
"I saw him yesterday." → He said he had seen him the day before.

Remember
If you report on the same day, you can keep the time words: 'He said he'd do it tomorrow' (said earlier today).

Part 3 · See the Difference

say vs tell (and ask)

say + that	tell + person	ask + person	The pattern
He said that he was busy.	He told me that he was busy.	He asked me if I was busy.	say + that (no person) · tell + person · ask + person + question

reporting with the same tense or backshift

Reported later (backshift)	Still true now (no shift)	The rule
She said she was tired. (reported later)	She said she is tired. (still true now)	Both can be correct: backshift for reporting later; no shift when the fact is still true — or when you report immediately.

command vs request vs advice

order: told me to wait	request: asked me to wait	advice: advised me to wait	insistence: insisted on my waiting	The force
told me to wait	asked me to wait	advised me to wait	insisted on my waiting	The verb carries the force: order → request → advice → insistence.

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete or correct the sentences.

1. "I am working now." → He said he _____ (work) then.
2. "We have finished." → They said they _____ (finish).
3. "Where did you park?" → She asked me where I _____ (park).
4. "Don't touch it!" → He warned me _____ touch it.
5. "I'll help you." → She promised _____ (help) me.
6. "Let's take a break." → He suggested _____ (take) a break.

B. Choose, transform or build.

1. Report: 'I never lie.' (He said…)
2. Report a question: 'When will the results be announced?' (They asked…)
3. Correct: 'He said me that he was tired.'
4. Correct: 'She suggested me to go early.'
5. Report with a strong verb: 'No, I didn't break the window.' (He denied…)
6. Report advice your teacher has given you (2 sentences, 2 different reporting verbs).

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Work with a partner

The message game. Partner A reads (or says) three short messages from 'other people' (notes, emails, quotes). Partner B reports them to a third person (the teacher/another pair) using different reporting verbs. Swap.

• Messages to report: a complaint · a promise · a warning · an invitation · a refusal.
• Use at least four different reporting verbs and both question and command reports.

Expected output: Five faithfully reported messages per reporter, using at least four different reporting verbs, with one reported question and one reported command, that the listener can repeat accurately.

Success criteria

✓ backshift is accurate
✓ question word order correct in reports
✓ at least four reporting verbs used
✓ time references shifted correctly

Part 6 · The Advanced Upgrade

Intermediate — build accuracy

• Drill the backshift table out loud with true sentences about your day.
• Learn the verb patterns in chunks: 'admitted -ing' · 'promised to' · 'warned me not to' · 'suggested -ing'.

Advanced — build flexibility

• Use continuous reporting verbs for liveliness: 'She kept insisting that she was right.' · 'He went on to explain…'
• Use 'point out / observe / note' in academic reporting: 'The report points out that demand has fallen.'
• Report with judgement-free precision: 'He claimed to have seen nothing, yet witnesses disagreed.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Plan first

Planning (30 seconds): choose a real conversation and list four things that were said — keywords only, with who said each one. Pick your four reporting verbs before you speak: admitted, warned, promised, suggested, agreed, asked…

Speak now — without reading

Retell challenge (ninety seconds): report a real conversation you had this week — a discussion, an argument, an interview or a negotiation. Report at least four things people said, using varied reporting verbs. End with your own comment.

Model response — speak first, then compare; one strong example, not the only answer

On Saturday my sister called to tell me that she had accepted the job offer. She admitted that she was nervous, but she promised to ask for a training week. My father warned her not to sign without reading the contract, and she agreed to send it to him first. She also asked me whether I thought she should negotiate the salary; I suggested doing the same research she had done for the interview. In my opinion, she should ask — the worst they can say is no.

Partner feedback — listen for

✓ accurate backshift and time references
✓ varied reporting verbs (not only 'said')
✓ questions and commands reported correctly
✓ clear final comment

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Key learning points

• Backshift: one tense back; time words shift too.
• say (+ that) vs tell (+ person); reported questions use statement order.
• Reporting verbs (admit, promise, warn, suggest…) carry meaning and grammar patterns.

Retrieval practice — cover the page, then say

• Report three things someone said to you today.
• Report one question, one command and one promise — all out loud.

Watch out

• 'He said me…' → 'He told me…'.

• 'She suggested me to go' → 'She suggested going' / 'She suggested that I go'.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can report statements, questions and commands accurately.

☐ I use reporting verbs beyond 'say'.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 13 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

A. was working had finished had parked (or: parked) not to to help taking
B. He said (that) he never lied. / He said (that) he never lies. They asked when the results would be announced. He told me that he was tired. She suggested going early. / She suggested that I go early. He denied breaking the window.
answers vary

LESSON 14 · PARTICIPLES AND ADVANCED SENTENCE PATTERNS

Part 7 — Sound More Natural and Advanced | Speaking goal: combine ideas concisely without losing clarity

Participles are how English professionals compress ideas — speed without confusion.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start here — talk first

Combine these ideas aloud, any way you like:
• The team was exhausted. They finished the project on time.
• She opened the letter. She found the news she had waited for.
Which version sounds most professional?

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Present and past participles as adjectives

Formula

-ing (present participle) → causes the feeling: a boring lecture
-ed (past participle) → feels the effect: bored students

The rule: things are -ing; people (and animals) are usually -ed — because they feel it.

Examples

The film was fascinating. (the film causes interest)
I was fascinated. (I felt it)
tiring work / tired workers · confusing news / confused readers

Remember

Some -ing words describe a person's behaviour instead: 'He is very interesting' (he holds my attention) vs 'He is very interested' (he feels interest).

Rule 2 — Participial clauses: the professional connector

Formula

Verb-ing …, subject + verb → same time / reason
Having + past participle …, subject + verb → earlier action
Past participle …, subject + verb → passive meaning
Used carefully, these replace 'because/after/while + full clause'

Participial clauses open or close a sentence with compressed information. Use them in formal speech and writing.

Examples

Having finished the report, she left the office. (After she had finished…)
Written in 1963, the novel is still popular. (The novel, which was written…)
Walking to the station, I realised my mistake. (While I was walking…)

Remember

In a reduced opening clause with no stated subject, the understood subject should match the main clause: 'Walking to the station, I got soaked' (I was walking), not 'Walking to the station, the rain started.' An absolute clause names its own subject: 'With prices rising, families are worried.'

Rule 3 — Absolute and fronted patterns for emphasis

Formula

Fronted participle: 'Considering the costs…', 'Given the evidence…', 'Looking at the results…'
With + noun + participle: 'With prices rising, families are worried.'
Having been + participle: 'Having been warned, we prepared carefully.'

These patterns frame a whole clause — they sound composed and formal.

Examples

Given the circumstances, we agreed to wait.
With the deadline approaching, the team worked faster.
All things considered, it was a success.

Remember
'Given' = when you consider; 'considering' = taking into account; 'all things considered' = final judgement phrase.

Rule 4 — Concise combination: fewer words, same meaning

Formula
'She opened the letter and she read it slowly.' → 'Opening the letter, she read it slowly.'
Two actions → one main verb + participle (if the subject is the same).

Concision is not using difficult words; it is removing whole clauses.

Examples
Because he had not slept, he made mistakes. → Not having slept, he made mistakes.
The report, which was published today, contains errors. → The report published today contains errors.

Remember
Do not over-compress speech. One or two participial clauses per answer is plenty.

Part 3 · See the Difference

-ing vs -ed adjectives

-ing (causes the feeling)	-ed (feels it)	Example
an exciting game	excited players	The game causes excitement; the players feel it.
a tiring day	tired students	The day causes tiredness; the students experience it.

participle clause vs full clause

Participle clause (compressed)	Full clause	Why
Having finished, she left.	After she had finished, she left.	Same meaning; the participle version is compressed and formal.
Written in haste, the report had errors.	The report, which was written in haste, had errors.	Compression with a passive participle.

the subject rule

In a reduced participle clause with no stated subject, the understood subject should normally match the main clause: 'Opening the door, I felt the cold.' (I opened), not 'Opening the door, the room was cold.' Absolute clauses state their own subject, as in 'Weather permitting, we will leave.'

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete or correct the sentences.

1. The lecture was so _____ (bore) that half the class fell asleep.
2. We were _____ (amaze) by the results.
3. _____ (finish) his speech, he answered questions.
4. _____ (warn) about the traffic, we left early.
5. _____ the prices rising, families are saving more. (with / despite)
6. _____ (walk) into the room, she noticed the broken window.

B. Choose, transform or build.

1. Combine with a participle: 'Because she had studied hard, she passed easily.'
2. Combine with a participle: 'The man who was standing at the door waved.'
3. Correct: 'Opening the window, the cold air came in.'
4. Rewrite with 'Given': 'When you consider the costs, the plan is unrealistic.'
5. Correct: 'I am very interesting in history.'
6. Compress one of your own sentences with 'Having + past participle'.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Work with a partner

The formal briefing. Each partner gives a 60-second briefing on a situation (a project, a trip, an event). The briefing must use at least two participle clauses.

- Include: one 'Having + past participle', one opening with 'Given/Considering/With', and one -ed/-ing adjective pair.
- Partner listens and reports the briefing back in one sentence.

Expected output: One 60-second briefing per partner containing the three required structures, plus a listener's one-sentence report-back that matches the briefing's content.

Success criteria

✓ participle clauses have correct subjects
✓ forms are accurate (-ing / -ed / having done)
✓ meaning stays clear after compression
✓ listener's report matches the content

Part 6 · The Advanced Upgrade

Intermediate — build accuracy

- Drill -ed/-ing pairs about real life: tired/tiring, confused/confusing, interested/interesting — five sentences.
- Practise the subject rule: make two correct participle openings from your week.

Advanced — build flexibility

- Use 'There being + noun': 'There being no further questions, the meeting ended.'
- Use 'Not having… / Never having…': 'Never having travelled abroad, he found the airport overwhelming.'
- Use participles in formal closings: 'Considering all the evidence, we recommend…'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Plan first

Planning (45 seconds): choose the policy and write three lines — your evidence, your recommendation, your closing judgement. Mark where 'Given…' and 'Having…' will go so the openings come out whole.

Speak now — without reading

Ninety-second formal recommendation: recommend one policy for your workplace or school (more training, a schedule change, a new rule). Open with 'Considering…' or 'Given…', use one 'Having…' clause, and close formally.

Model response — speak first, then compare; one strong example, not the only answer

Given the number of late arrivals, we recommend shifting the morning meeting to nine o'clock. Having reviewed the attendance records, I noticed that most delays happen before ten, when the traffic is heaviest. The current schedule is frustrating for parents, and several tired employees arrive unprepared. Considering the cost of the change — none — the benefit is obvious. All things considered, a two-week trial would settle the question.

Partner feedback — listen for

✓ at least two accurate participle clauses
✓ -ed/-ing adjectives used correctly
✓ recommendation is clear and logical
✓ formal, composed tone

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Key learning points

- -ing adjectives cause feelings; -ed adjectives feel them.
- Participle clauses compress because/after/while clauses — subject must match.
- 'Given…', 'Considering…', 'With + noun + participle' frame formal speech.

Retrieval practice — cover the page, then say

- Open a sentence with 'Having…' about your day.
- Describe today with one -ing and one -ed adjective.

Watch out

- 'Opening the window, the room was cold.' (subject mismatch).
- 'interesting in' → 'interested in'.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can compress two clauses into one formal sentence.

☐ My participle clauses keep the correct subject.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 14 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

A. boring amazed Having finished Having been warned / Warned With Walking
B. Having studied hard, she passed easily. The man standing at the door waved. Opening the window, I felt the cold air come in. / As I opened the window, the cold air came in. Given the costs, the plan is unrealistic. I am very interested in history. answers vary

LESSON 15 · HEDGING, EMPHASIS, AND NATURAL INVERSION

Part 8 — Speak with Confidence | Speaking goal: control certainty, emphasis and formality like an educated speaker

The difference between good and excellent English is control: how strong, how sure, how formal.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start here — talk first

Two speakers say: 'The plan will fail.' / 'The plan may well fail.' Which sounds more educated? Why?
Give the same opinion twice: once very certain, once carefully hedged. How does the effect change?

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Hedging: the art of careful claims

Formula

may / might / could + base verb · may well · it is likely that ...
seem to / tend to / appear to · generally / broadly / in most cases
it could be argued that ... · one possible explanation is ...

Hedging can make a claim sound measured when evidence is limited or a conclusion is uncertain. Academic and professional speakers often hedge; too much hedging, however, can make a message unclear.

Examples

The results suggest a small improvement.
This policy may well reduce costs in the long run.
It could be argued that the data is incomplete.

Remember

Too many hedges sound vague: 'It might perhaps possibly be...' — one careful hedge per claim is enough.

Rule 2 — Emphasis: clefts and focus

Formula

It is/was + emphasised part + who/that ... (cleft)
What I need is ... · What surprised me was ... (wh-cleft)
do/does/did + base verb (auxiliary emphasis): 'I do believe you.'

Cleft sentences split one idea in two to put the spotlight on one part.

Examples

It was the price that changed my mind. (not the quality)
What I love about this city is its energy.
She did call — I saw the message.

Remember

In speech, stress the focused word: 'It was JOHN who...'.

Rule 3 — Inversion: formal emphasis

Formula

Negative opener + auxiliary + subject + verb:
Never have I seen ... · Not only did she ..., but she also ...
Rarely / Seldom / Little / Nowhere + auxiliary + subject + verb
Only + adverbial + auxiliary + subject + verb: Only then did I understand ...
No sooner ... than ... · Hardly ... when ... · Under no circumstances ...

When a sentence begins with a strong negative or limiting phrase, English reverses the order — like raising your voice politely.

Examples

Never have I been so surprised.
Not only did he apologise, but he also refunded the money.
Only after the meeting did I understand the decision.

Remember
Inversion is punctuation for the ear. Use it once for impact — never in every sentence.

Rule 4 — Choosing the right level of certainty and formality

Formula
Strong prediction/inference: will (prediction) · must be (strong deduction)
Expectation/likelihood: should · be likely to · may well
Possibility: may · might · could (no fixed ranking; context and speaker matter)
formal markers: passive · inversion · clefts · hedging · full forms

Match the strength of your language to your evidence and your audience. Over-claiming damages credibility; careful claims build it.

Examples
Formal: 'Should you require further information, please do not hesitate to contact us.'
Neutral: 'If you need more information, contact us.'
Casual: 'Just call me if you need anything.'

Remember
A careful hedge signals that you are matching the strength of your claim to the evidence — not that you lack confidence.

Part 3 · See the Difference

certainty levels

Certain: will	Likely: may well	Possible: might	The idea
The plan will succeed. (certain)	The plan may well succeed. (likely)	The plan might succeed. (possible)	Same claim, three levels of commitment.

normal order vs inversion

Normal order	Inversion (emphatic)	The effect
I have never seen such a mess.	Never have I seen such a mess.	The inverted version is emphatic and formal — powerful in speeches, heavy in casual chat.

cleft focus changes meaning

Basic sentence	It-cleft	Wh-cleft	The idea
I met the manager yesterday.	It was the manager who I met yesterday.	What I did yesterday was meet the manager.	Each version puts the spotlight in a different place.

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete or correct the sentences.

1. _____ have I heard such a convincing argument. (Never / Ever)
2. Not only _____ (she / pass) the exam, but she also got the highest mark.
3. Only after reading it twice _____ (I / understand) the letter.
4. The data _____ (suggest) that costs are falling. (hedged claim)
5. It was _____ the deadline that forced us to decide. (focus on the reason)
6. This method _____ (tend) to work better with small groups.

B. Choose, transform or build.

1. Hedge the claim: 'This policy will reduce costs.'
2. Make a cleft: 'The price changed my mind.' (focus the price)
3. Invert: 'I had rarely felt so confident.'
4. Correct: 'Never I have seen such a mess.'
5. Say the same request at two formality levels: you need more time for a report.
6. Use 'Not only … but also' with inversion about two of your skills.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Work with a partner

The panel discussion. Question: 'What will work look like in ten years?' Each partner gives a one-minute answer using hedging and at least one emphatic structure (cleft or inversion). Then ask each other one hard follow-up question.
• Plan for ten seconds only. In your answer include: one hedge (may well / tend to / it could be argued), one cleft (It is… that / What… is), and one conclusion.
• Answer the follow-up question carefully — hedging is welcome when you are unsure.
Expected output: Two one-minute answers per partner, each containing one well-placed hedge, one accurate emphasis structure and a clear conclusion — plus one careful answer to the partner's hard follow-up question.

Success criteria

✓ claims are hedged appropriately (not over-hedged)
✓ emphasis structures used accurately once or twice
✓ certainty level matches the evidence
✓ answers stay clear and confident

Part 6 · The Advanced Upgrade

Intermediate — build accuracy

• Practise three certainty groups in context: strong prediction/inference (will / must be), expectation or likelihood (should / may well), and possibility (may / might / could). Explain what evidence supports each choice.
• Learn three inversion frames by heart: 'Never have I…' · 'Not only did…' · 'Only then did…'.

Advanced — build flexibility

• Use 'little did he know…' and 'little did I realise…' in storytelling.
• Use litotes (understatement): 'not unlike', 'no small achievement', 'not bad at all'.
• Use formal conditional inversion in writing-style speech: 'Were this proposal accepted…' · 'Had we known…'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Plan first

Planning (30 seconds): one claim plus its evidence for the hedge; one fact worth spotlighting for the cleft; one strong statement for the inversion. Write single keywords, not sentences — you will not read them.

Speak now — without reading

Two-minute formal talk: 'One change that would improve education in my country.' Include: a hedged claim, one cleft sentence, one inversion, and a clear closing. Speak with confidence — no notes.

Model response — speak first, then compare; one strong example, not the only answer

Education in my country will change in one area above all: access. It is broadband that will decide who benefits from that change. Rarely have we seen technology move so quickly in our cities, yet rural schools are often left without a reliable connection. The government could take the first step by funding internet in district centres — this may well be the cheapest investment of the decade. If the infrastructure were in place, teachers could share materials overnight. In closing, I would say one thing: connect the schools first, and the rest will follow.

Partner feedback — listen for

✓ hedging used for claims, not for every word
✓ at least one cleft and one inversion — accurate
✓ register is consistently formal
✓ closing states the position clearly

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Key learning points

• Hedging (may well, tend to, it could be argued) makes claims professional.
• Clefts and do-emphasis spotlight information: 'It was X that…' / 'What I need is…'.
• Inversion follows negative openers: 'Never have I…' — use for impact, sparingly.

Retrieval practice — cover the page, then say

• Make one claim at three certainty levels.
• Say one cleft and one inversion from memory.

Watch out

• 'Never I have seen' → 'Never have I seen'.
• Over-hedging sounds vague; over-inverting sounds theatrical.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can control how strong my claims sound.

☐ I can emphasise with clefts and inversion — accurately and sparingly.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 15 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

A. Never did she pass did I understand suggests (or: suggest) the deadline tends
B. This policy may well reduce costs. / This policy is likely to reduce costs. It was the price that changed my mind. Rarely had I felt so confident. Never have I seen such a mess. answers vary answers vary

LESSON 16 · GRAMMAR IN REAL CONVERSATION

Part 8 — Speak with Confidence | Speaking goal: bring all the course grammar together in free, accurate, confident speech

This lesson is not new theory — it is the moment everything you have learned becomes your voice.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start here — talk first

Warm-up round with a partner: speak for thirty seconds on any topic. Your partner listens and names every grammar structure they recognise (tenses, conditionals, passives...). Swap.

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

The course grammar: one map

Formula

TIME: tenses · storytelling · reported speech
CHOICE: modals · conditionals · wishes · gerunds/infinitives
SHAPE: questions · linkers · relatives · participles · passive · causative
STYLE: comparisons · hedging · emphasis · inversion

Every lesson in this course belongs to one of these four jobs. When you speak, ask: what job does my next sentence need?

Examples

Tell the story (time) → explain the cause (choice) → describe the people (shape) → give your view (style).

Remember

Accuracy first, then range. A clear sentence in the right tense beats a fancy one in the wrong tense.

The speaking strategy: three steps to confident speech

Formula

1. THINK the meaning → 2. CHOOSE the structure → 3. SAY it whole
If stuck: simplify — and keep going. Repair later: 'What I mean is...'

Fluency is not speed; it is continuity. Keep the message moving and fix problems as you go.

Examples

'If I would have known...' — stop, repair: 'If I had known, I would have come.'

Remember

Self-repair is a strength in speaking tests — it shows control.

Part 3 · See the Difference

recognition vs use

You already recognise most course structures. The final step is producing them under pressure — that is what the challenges below train.

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete or correct the sentences.

1. Fix and explain: 'I have seen him yesterday.'
2. Fix and explain: 'If I will have time, I will help.'
3. Fix and explain: 'Despite of the price, we bought it.'
4. Fix and explain: 'He suggested me to wait.'
5. Fix and explain: 'Never I have been so tired.'
6. Fix and explain: 'I look forward to meet you.'

B. Choose, transform or build.

1. Combine (participles): 'Because he had not slept, he made errors.'

2. Report: 'Don't worry,' she said. (2 forms)

3. Compare with nuance: 'This option is better.' (use a degree word + reason)

4. Make it passive and formal: 'Someone has changed the schedule.'

5. Hedge the claim: 'This method is the best.'

6. Ask a polite indirect question about tomorrow's schedule.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Work with a partner

The grammar gym — four rounds. Each round: speak for one minute on the topic, using the target structures. Partner counts the structures used and gives feedback.
• Round 1 — Storytelling: a challenge you overcame. (tenses, participles)
• Round 2 — Advice: a friend must choose between two jobs. (modals, conditionals)
• Round 3 — Report: what your colleagues or classmates have decided. (reported speech, passives)
• Round 4 — Argument: one change that would improve your school or workplace. (linkers, hedging, emphasis)
Expected output: Four one-minute rounds per pair: each round delivered without notes, with the target structures counted aloud and at least one self-repair noted by the listener.

Success criteria

✓ structures match the round's target
✓ errors are self-corrected during speech
✓ ideas are clear and well-linked
✓ confidence and continuity are maintained

Part 6 · The Advanced Upgrade

Intermediate — build accuracy

• Re-do any lesson exercise that felt hard — out loud, not on paper.
• For each of the four jobs (time / choice / shape / style), write three sentences from your own life.

Advanced — build flexibility

• Stack structures in one sentence: 'Had I known that the report would be delayed, I would have asked for help.'
• Use style deliberately: open a talk with an inversion, hedge your main claim, close with a cleft.
• Practise repair phrases: 'What I mean is…' · 'Let me rephrase that…' · 'Or rather…'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Plan first

Planning (one minute): three lines only — the story (when and what changed), the decision (what you chose and why), the goal (what comes next and how you will know you have reached it). Then deliberately choose two 'show-off' structures.

Speak now — without reading

Final speaking challenge (two minutes): 'How I have changed — and what comes next.' Tell a story, explain a decision, and state a goal. Use at least six different structures from the course. This is also your practice for the Final Speaking Assessment.

Model response — speak first, then compare; one strong example, not the only answer

Two years ago I avoided speaking English in class because I was afraid of mistakes — I would translate every sentence in my head first. Joining a speaking club changed that: within a month, I had made friends who corrected me kindly. Since then I have been practising almost every day, and my teachers have noticed the difference. I've decided to take the TOEFL next spring, which is why I'm recording myself twice a week. If I keep this up, the score will take care of itself. What I need most now is confidence under pressure — and that comes only from speaking.

Partner feedback — listen for

✓ range of structures used accurately
✓ clear story shape with linking
✓ at least one hedged or emphatic structure
✓ confident, continuous delivery with natural self-repair

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Key learning points

- Course grammar does four jobs: time, choice, shape, style.
- Speak in three steps: think meaning → choose structure → say it whole.
- Accuracy first, then range; self-repair shows control.

Retrieval practice — cover the page, then say

- Name all four grammar jobs and one structure for each.
- Tell a one-minute story using three different course structures.

Watch out

- Choosing complexity over accuracy — simple and correct is always better.
- Freezing on errors — repair and continue instead.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can use structures from at least six lessons in free speech.

☐ I can self-repair and keep talking.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 16 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

A. I saw him yesterday. (finished time) If I have time, I will help. Despite the price, we bought it. / Although it was expensive, we bought it. He suggested waiting. / He suggested that I wait. Never have I been so tired. I look forward to meeting you.
B. Not having slept, he made errors. She told me not to worry. / She reassured me. answers vary — degree word + reason required The schedule has been changed. This method may well be the best. / This method is probably the best. (answers vary) answers vary — indirect word order required

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Part 1: Grammar knowledge · Part 2: Independent speaking task

Part 1 — Grammar knowledge (30 questions · suggested time: 35 minutes)

Section A — Complete the sentences. (12 questions)

1. I _____ (live) here since 2020.
2. When I got home, my family _____ (already / have) dinner.
3. If it _____ (be) sunny tomorrow, we'll go to the lake.
4. I wish I _____ (not/say) that yesterday.
5. The meeting _____ (cancel) yesterday afternoon.
6. You look exhausted — you _____ (must / work) all night. (past deduction)
7. She avoided _____ (make) any promises.
8. The teacher made us _____ (rewrite) the essay.
9. This is the most _____ (challenge) course I've ever taken.
10. _____ (warn) about the storm, the fishermen stayed ashore.
11. He suggested _____ (leave) before the traffic.
12. Not only _____ (she / apologise), but she also offered a refund.

Section B — Rewrite or transform. (10 questions)

13. Report: 'I'll help you tomorrow,' he said.
14. Report: 'Where did you buy it?' (She asked me…)
15. Polite question: 'When does the shop close?'
16. Third conditional: 'He didn't revise, so he failed.'
17. Passive (formal): 'Someone has stolen the documents.'
18. Cleft (focus the manager): 'The manager approved the plan.'
19. Causative: 'I paid someone to fix the roof.'
20. Inversion: 'She had rarely felt so confident.'
21. Combine with although: 'The task was difficult. They finished it.'
22. Combine with a participle: 'Because he had studied hard, he passed easily.'

Section C — Use and communication. (8 questions)

23. Choose: He (mustn't / can't) be at home — his car is gone.
24. Complete with a linker: _____ being expensive, the course is worth it.
25. Hedge the claim: 'This method is the best.' (may well / probably)
26. Compare with nuance: 'Option A is better than Option B.' (use far + give a reason frame)
27. Correct: 'The book what I read was amazing.'
28. Complete: The more you practise, the _____ (confident) you become.
29. Report advice: 'You should apply early,' she said. (She advised…)
30. Complete with the right pattern: I look forward to _____ (meet) you.

Stop here until you have completed all 30 items. The answer key is in Appendix 5.

Accept alternative answers where the exercise allows them (e.g. 'may well' / 'probably' / 'is likely to' for hedging). The Diagnostic Test is a broad starting snapshot, not a parallel form of this 30-item assessment. Do not compare the raw grammar totals as a measure of gain; compare your four speaking-rubric criterion scores instead.

FINAL ASSESSMENT — PART 2

Independent speaking task and evaluation

Speaking task (2 minutes to prepare · 2 minutes to speak, then follow-up exchange)

Speak on ONE of the following topics:
• A decision that changed your life — and what you would do differently today.
• One change that would improve education or work in your country.
• A person who influenced you, and the advice they gave you.
After your talk, a partner asks two follow-up questions. Answer them, then ask one relevant question in return. If you get stuck, repair and continue.
You may make brief notes during the preparation time. Speak without reading a script.

Evaluation rubric

Criterion	4 — Strong	3 — Good	2 — Developing	1 — Beginning
Grammatical accuracy	structures are consistently accurate; occasional slips do not affect meaning	generally accurate; some errors, meaning always clear	frequent errors; meaning sometimes unclear	errors dominate; meaning often unclear
Appropriate structure selection	wide range used naturally (tenses, conditionals, linkers, hedging…) for the intended meaning	good range; choices usually match the meaning	limited range; some structures forced or inappropriate	basic structures only; frequent wrong choices
Clarity	ideas well organised and easy to follow; effective linking	clear overall; some linking	ideas loosely connected; hard to follow at times	ideas listed without clear connection
Successful communication	message fully delivered; natural delivery, relevant follow-up exchange and self-repair	message delivered; answers and asks relevant follow-ups, with some hesitation	message partly delivered; responses are limited or pauses are long	message largely not delivered; little response to questions

Score: ____ / 16 Compare each criterion with your recorded Diagnostic speaking score.

Personal error analysis and improvement plan

Copy every error you made in the Final Assessment (written and spoken) into the table. An error that is analysed is halfway to being fixed.

My error	Correct form	Why it happened (rule I forgot)	My fix — where I will practise it

My next three goals:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Remember: improvement is measured by what you can do in speech — not by pages completed. Record yourself speaking for two minutes on the same topic in a month, and listen to the difference.

APPENDIX 1 · GRAMMAR FORMULA BOOK

Sixteen cards — one per lesson. Review with this book closed first.

Card 1 — Tenses for Real Communication

Present simple = facts & habits · Present continuous = around now
Past simple = finished time · Present perfect = connected to now
going to = plan · will = decision/prediction · present continuous = arrangement

Card 2 — Telling Stories

Past continuous = the scene · past simple = the events · past perfect = the earlier past
when + past simple · while + past continuous · by the time + past perfect before past simple
Shape: background → events (First... Then...) → ending/reflection

Card 3 — Questions and Follow-ups

Wh- + auxiliary + subject + verb · Yes/No: auxiliary + subject + verb
Indirect: question word + subject + verb (no inversion) — 'Do you know where the bank is?'
Follow-ups keep conversations alive: 'Really? What happened next? How about you?'

Card 4 — Modal Verbs

Modal + base verb: can/could = ability · may/could = permission · must/have to = obligation · should = advice · might = possibility
must be = certainly (positive) · might be = possible · can't be = certainly not
mustn't = prohibition ≠ can't (deduction) · Would you mind + -ing?

Card 5 — Conditionals

Zero: If + present, present · First: If + present, will + verb
Second: If + past, would + verb · Third: If + past perfect, would have + participle
Mixed: If + past perfect, would + verb · unless = if not · ordinary future if-clause: present simple

Card 6 — Wishes and Regrets

wish + past simple = present wish · wish + past perfect = past regret
wish + would = complaint/request · If only...! = strong emotion
would rather + base (me) / + past (someone else) · It's (high) time + past

Card 7 — Comparisons

comparative + than (compare two) · superlative (extreme in a group) · as + adj + as
the + comparative, the + comparative · comparative + and + comparative
far / much / slightly / by far + comparison · comparisons persuade with reasons

Card 8 — Linking and Arguments

although + clause · despite / in spite of + noun or -ing · however = new sentence
because + clause · because of + noun · therefore / as a result = consequence
Argument skeleton: POINT → REASON → EXAMPLE → SUMMARY

Card 9 — Passive Voice

be + past participle (tense lives in 'be'): is done · was done · will be done · has been done · must be done
Use: result matters · doer unknown/obvious/general · objective tone
It is said that ... = He is said to ...

Card 10 — Causative Structures

have/get + object + participle = arrange a service (or: something happened to me)
make + person + base (force) · let + base (allow) · have + base (instruct) · get + to (persuade)
'get' keeps 'to' — the other three don't.

Card 11 — Gerunds and Infinitives

enjoy/avoid/mind/suggest/keep + -ing · decide/hope/plan/promise/refuse + to
remember/forget/stop/try: -ing = earlier action · to = later action
Preposition + -ing — including 'to' in look forward to / be used to

Card 12 — Relative Clauses

who (people) · which (things) · that (both) · whose · where — object pronouns can drop
Defining = no commas (identifies) · Non-defining = commas (extra detail, no 'that')
Reduced: 'the man (who is) standing there' — only drop who is / which was

Card 13 — Reported Speech

Backshift one tense: present → past → past perfect · will → would · can → could
ask + if/whether or question word + statement order · told/asked + person + to
say (+ that) vs tell (+ person) · time words shift: tomorrow → the next day

Card 14 — Participles

-ing adjective = causes feeling · -ed adjective = feels it (boring lecture / bored class)
Participle clause: 'Having finished, she left.' — subject must match the main clause
Frames: Given... / Considering... / With + noun + -ing

Card 15 — Hedging, Emphasis, Inversion

Hedge: may well / might / tend to / it could be argued that ...
Cleft: It was X that ... / What I need is ... · do-emphasis: 'I do believe...'
Inversion after negative openers: Never have I... / Not only did... / Only then did...

Card 16 — Grammar in Real Conversation

Four jobs: TIME (tenses, reported) · CHOICE (modals, conditionals, wishes) · SHAPE (questions, linkers, relatives, passives) · STYLE (comparison, hedging, emphasis)
Think meaning → choose structure → say it whole
Accuracy first, then range; repair and continue: 'What I mean is...'

APPENDIX 2 · COMMON ERRORS AND CORRECTIONS GUIDE

Thirty errors that mark learners — and the fix for each

✗ Error	✓ Correction	Why
I have seen him yesterday.	I saw him yesterday.	finished time needs past simple
I am knowing the answer.	I know the answer.	state verbs take simple forms
She is more taller than me.	She is taller than me.	no double comparatives
This is better then that.	This is better than that.	than (comparison) not then (time)
If it will rain, we'll stay.	If it rains, we'll stay.	present simple in an ordinary future condition
If I would have known…	If I had known…	third conditional: if + past perfect
I wish I have more time.	I wish I had more time.	wish + past for unreal present
I'd rather you don't smoke.	I'd rather you didn't smoke.	would rather + subject + past
It's time we will go.	It's time we went.	it's time + past (already late)
Despite of the cost…	Despite the cost… / In spite of the cost…	no 'despite of'
Although the cost, we bought it.	Despite the cost, we bought it.	although + clause; despite + noun
Do you know where is the bank?	Do you know where the bank is?	indirect questions use statement order
Did she called you?	Did she call you?	base verb after did
He said me that he was tired.	He told me that he was tired.	tell + person; say + that
She suggested me to wait.	She suggested waiting.	suggest + -ing (or that + clause)
I look forward to meet you.	I look forward to meeting you.	'to' here is a preposition
I enjoy to read.	I enjoy reading.	enjoy + -ing
He made me to wait.	He made me wait.	make + person + base verb
I will get my car to repair.	I will get my car repaired.	have/get + object + participle
The house was builted in 1990.	The house was built in 1990.	past participle of build = built
My phone was stolen by me.	I lost my phone.	active is clearer for your own actions
The book what I read…	The book (that) I read…	no 'what' as a relative pronoun
My mother, that lives…	My mother, who lives…	'that' is not used after commas
Never I have seen such a mess.	Never have I seen such a mess.	inversion after negative openers
He mustn't be at home.	He can't be at home.	can't = deduction; mustn't = prohibition
Would you mind to open the window?	Would you mind opening the window?	mind + -ing
I am very interesting in history.	I am very interested in history.	-ed = feels; -ing = causes
Opening the window, the room was cold.	Opening the window, I felt the cold.	participle subject must match
He denied to break it.	He denied breaking it.	deny + -ing
Unless you don't hurry…	Unless you hurry…	'unless' already means 'if not'

APPENDIX 3 · ESSENTIAL SENTENCE PATTERNS FOR SPEAKING

Build answers from these skeletons until they are automatic

Function	Patterns
Experience	I have (never) … · One experience that changed me was …
Story	First … Then … After that … Suddenly … Finally …
Opinion	I believe that … because … · From my point of view …
Reason	This is mainly because … · The main reason is that …
Example	For instance … · A good example of this is …
Contrast	Although …, … · Despite + noun/-ing … · On the other hand …
Concession	It is true that …; nevertheless … · Admittedly …; even so …
Result	As a result … · This means that … · Consequently …
Hedged claim	It could be argued that … · … may well … · … tend(s) to …
Emphasis	It is … that … · What I mean is … · I do believe …
Advice	If I were you, I'd … · You might want to … · It might be worth …
Regret	I wish I had … · If only I had … · What I should have done was …
Preference	I'd rather … than … · I prefer … to … · If I had to choose, I'd …
Prediction	In the future, … will probably … · … is likely to …
Polite request	Would you mind …-ing? · Could I possibly …? · I was wondering if …
Reporting	He said (that) … · She pointed out that … · They warned me not to …
Description	…, who/which … · The person who … · …, which means that …
Comparison	… is far more … than … · The more …, the more … · … is by far the most …
Process	First, … is done; then … is … · Having been …, … · … is then …
Summary	To sum up … · All in all … · The point I want to make is …
Self-repair	What I mean is … · Let me rephrase that … · Or rather …
Ending	That's why … · This taught me that … · Looking ahead, I plan to …

APPENDIX 4 · SPEAKING SELF-ASSESSMENT AND CAN-DO TRACKER

Tick honestly: ✓ = I can do this in speech · ~ = almost · ✗ = not yet

Lesson	Can-do statement	Before the course	After Lesson 16
Lesson 1	I can talk about habits, current situations and past experiences accurately.		
Lesson 2	I can tell a story with background, clear sequence and a meaningful ending.		
Lesson 3	I can ask polite questions and keep a conversation going with follow-ups.		
Lesson 4	I can give advice, express obligation and show degrees of certainty with the right modal.		
Lesson 5	I can discuss real possibilities, imaginary situations and unreal pasts.		
Lesson 6	I can express wishes, regrets and preferences naturally.		
Lesson 7	I can compare options and support my comparisons with reasons.		
Lesson 8	I can link ideas and build a short argument with a clear skeleton.		
Lesson 9	I can choose active or passive for the right focus in reports and descriptions.		
Lesson 10	I can talk about services, arrangements and influence using causatives.		
Lesson 11	I can use gerund and infinitive patterns accurately, including meaning changes.		
Lesson 12	I can describe people and places precisely with defining and non-defining clauses.		
Lesson 13	I can report statements, questions and commands with accurate backshift.		
Lesson 14	I can compress ideas with participles without losing clarity.		
Lesson 15	I can control certainty, emphasis and formality in formal speech.		
Lesson 16	I can use the course grammar together in free, confident conversation.		

Speaking self-assessment

Record yourself for two minutes (any topic) and rate yourself with the Final Assessment rubric. Repeat after one month and compare the recordings — that is your true progress.

APPENDIX 5 · COMPLETE ANSWER KEY

All exercises, review tests and the final assessment

Alternative answers are accepted where the exercise allows them. Speaking tasks are evaluated with the success criteria and rubric — not with rigid model answers.

Diagnostic

A. 1 saw · 2 has worked / has been working · 3 was cooking · 4 had worked / had been working; 'worked' is also possible with before · 5 boils · 6 were building · 7 have lost · 8 went · 9 have read · 10 had already left
B. 1 rains · 2 knew · 3 repairing / to be repaired · 4 was written · 5 leaving · 6 the station is · 7 who / that · 8 didn't smoke · 9 more intelligent · 10 did she finish
C. 1 can't · 2 Despite · 3 where I lived / where I live (if still true) · 4 may / might / could · 5 had / got

Lesson 1

Practice A. 1 saw · 2 has worked / has been working · 3 are meeting · 4 is snowing · 5 believes
Practice B. 1 I finished my homework last night. · 2 She knows the answer. · 3 have you known · 4 I'm going to study medicine.

Lesson 2

Practice A. 1 was studying · 2 had already eaten · 3 called / took · 4 was walking / saw · 5 had finished · 6 were playing / was resting
Practice B. 1 While I was reading the report, the printer broke. · 2 By the time we reached the station, the train had left. · 3 When I arrived, he had already left. · 4 answers vary · 5 while · 6 It was raining and I forgot my umbrella, so I got wet. (answers vary)

Lesson 3

Practice A. 1 have / tried · 2 happened · 3 the library is · 4 costs · 5 wrote · 6 did / write
Practice B. 1 Could you tell me where you parked? · 2 Do you know when the results will be ready? · 3 Do you know where the bank is? · 4 answers vary · 5 Did she call you? · 6 answers vary

Lesson 4

Practice A. 1 should · 2 could · 3 must · 4 mustn't · 5 might · 6 Would / opening
Practice B. 1 Could you open the window, please? / Would you mind opening the window? · 2 She must be at home. · 3 He might have missed the train. / He may have missed the train. · 4 He can't be at home — his lights are off. · 5 No, not at all. (No problem.) · 6 answers vary

Lesson 5

Practice A. 1 heat / boils · 2 rains / will cancel (or: 'll cancel) · 3 were / would apologise · 4 had left / wouldn't have missed · 5 knew / would call · 6 will go / stays
Practice B. 1 Unless you register, you can't attend. · 2 If he had studied, he wouldn't have failed. · 3 If she had saved money, she could buy the car now. / …would be able to buy… · 4 If I have time, I will help you. · 5 answers vary · 6 answers vary

Lesson 6

Practice A. 1 knew · 2 hadn't said · 3 owned · 4 made · 5 didn't tell · 6 were
Practice B. 1 I wish I had studied harder. · 2 I'd rather you didn't smoke here. / I'd rather you didn't smoke. · 3 I wish I had more time. · 4 It's time we went. · 5 reading / watching · 6 answers vary

Lesson 7

Practice A. 1 shorter · 2 the worst · 3 more / faster · 4 more beautifully · 5 as / as · 6 most talented
Practice B. 1 The new laptop is twice as expensive as the old one. · 2 She is taller than me. · 3 This method is far better than that one because it saves time. (answers vary) · 4 answers vary · 5 This is better than that. · 6 answers vary

Lesson 8

Practice A. 1 Despite · 2 Despite (not 'although' — it needs a clause: Although she was very tired) · 3 however · 4 so that · 5 As a result · 6 whereas
Practice B. 1 Although the task was difficult, everyone finished. · 2 Despite not being selected, she applied again. / Despite the rejection, she applied again. · 3 Despite the cost, we decided to proceed. · 4 answers vary — must include point, reason, example · 5 Despite the cost, we bought it. / Although it was costly, we bought it. · 6 answers vary — must open with To sum up / All in all / In conclusion

Lesson 9

Practice A. 1 was built · 2 will be announced · 3 is cleaned · 4 was stolen · 5 has just been introduced · 6 be sent
Practice B. 1 My bicycle has been stolen. · 2 The board made the decision. · 3 It is said that he is the best candidate. / He is said to be the best candidate. · 4 The house was built in 1990. · 5 I lost my phone. / I had my phone stolen. (answers vary) · 6 The road will be closed tomorrow.

Lesson 10

Practice A. 1 altered · 2 cut · 3 lose · 4 use · 5 tested · 6 to eat
Practice B. 1 I had my car serviced. · 2 I got my friend to drive us. / After much discussion, I got my friend to drive. · 3 I will get my car repaired tomorrow. · 4 She made me wait outside. · 5 answers vary · 6 Could you have my phone screen replaced? / How much would it cost to have my screen replaced?

Lesson 11

Practice A. 1 helping · 2 answering · 3 to accept · 4 hearing · 5 smoking · 6 to open
Practice B. 1 I enjoy reading novels. · 2 I look forward to meeting you. · 3 She suggested going early. · 4 The room needs cleaning. / The room needs to be cleaned. · 5 posting · 6 answers vary

Lesson 12

Practice A. 1 who · 2 which · 3 where · 4 whose · 5 (that) were / which were — or simply 'announced today' with 'The results announced today…' · 6 that (or which)
Practice B. 1 The teacher who taught me last year is excellent. · 2 My friend, who is a pilot, travels constantly. · 3 My mother, who lives in Kandahar, is visiting. · 4 The book (that) I read was amazing. · 5 Students interested in the course should apply. · 6 answers vary

Lesson 13

Practice A. 1 was working · 2 had finished · 3 had parked (or: parked) · 4 not to · 5 to help · 6 taking
Practice B. 1 He said (that) he never lied. / He said (that) he never lies. · 2 They asked when the results would be announced. · 3 He told me that he was tired. · 4 She suggested going early. / She suggested that I go early. · 5 He denied breaking the window. · 6 answers vary

Lesson 14

Practice A. 1 boring · 2 amazed · 3 Having finished · 4 Having been warned / Warned · 5 With · 6 Walking
Practice B. 1 Having studied hard, she passed easily. · 2 The man standing at the door waved. · 3 Opening the window, I felt the cold air come in. / As I opened the window, the cold air came in. · 4 Given the costs, the plan is unrealistic. · 5 I am very interested in history. · 6 answers vary

Lesson 15

Practice A. 1 Never · 2 did she pass · 3 did I understand · 4 suggests (or: suggest) · 5 the deadline · 6 tends
Practice B. 1 This policy may well reduce costs. / This policy is likely to reduce costs. · 2 It was the price that changed my mind. · 3 Rarely had I felt so confident. · 4 Never have I seen such a mess. · 5 answers vary · 6 answers vary

Lesson 16

Practice A. 1 I saw him yesterday. (finished time) · 2 If I have time, I will help. · 3 Despite the price, we bought it. / Although it was expensive, we bought it. · 4 He suggested waiting. / He suggested that I wait. · 5 Never have I been so tired. · 6 I look forward to meeting you.
Practice B. 1 Not having slept, he made errors. · 2 She told me not to worry. / She reassured me. · 3 answers vary — degree word + reason required · 4 The schedule has been changed. · 5 This method may well be the best. / This method is probably the best. (answers vary) · 6 answers vary — indirect word order required

Review Test 1

A. 1 haven't seen · 2 were waiting · 3 freezes · 4 is studying · 5 had eaten · 6 is going to rain / will rain · 7 have / known · 8 started
B. 1 must · 2 Would / closing · 3 is · 4 don't have to / needn't
C. 1 Answers vary; e.g., 'You should rest before driving.' (should + base verb) · 2 Could you tell me where you parked? · 3 must be

Review Test 2

A. 1 knew · 2 had taken · 3 more effective · 4 was reading · 5 had already left · 6 made · 7 best · 8 hurry
B. 1 Despite the exam being hard, everyone passed. / Despite the difficulty, everyone passed. · 2 If I had a car, I would drive you. / If I had a car, I could drive you. · 3 answers vary — advice with should/could/might · 4 Could you tell me where the bank is?
C. 1 If she had saved money, she could buy the car now. / …would be able to buy… · 2 answers vary — far + comparative + reason · 3 Despite the cost, we decided to proceed.

Review Test 3

A. 1 was built · 2 repaired · 3 to speak · 4 making · 5 where · 6 whose · 7 didn't mention · 8 knew
B. 1 The room needs cleaning. / The room needs to be cleaned. · 2 He must have missed the train. · 3 Students interested in the course should apply. · 4 It is believed that the economy is improving. / The economy is believed to be improving.
C. 1 more / more confident · 2 Do you know where the bank is? · 3 had · 4 I enjoy reading novels.

Final Assessment

A. 1 have lived / 've lived / have been living · 2 had already had · 3 is · 4 hadn't said · 5 was cancelled · 6 must have been working · 7 making · 8 rewrite · 9 challenging · 10 Warned / Having been warned · 11 leaving · 12 did she apologise
B. 1 He said he would help me the next day. · 2 She asked me where I had bought it. · 3 Could you tell me when the shop closes? · 4 If he had revised, he wouldn't have failed. · 5 The documents have been stolen. · 6 It was the manager who/that approved the plan. · 7 I had the roof fixed. · 8 Rarely had she felt so confident. · 9 Although the task was difficult, they finished it. · 10 Having studied hard, he passed easily.
C. 1 can't · 2 Despite · 3 This method may well be the best. / This method is probably the best. (answers vary) · 4 Option A is far better than Option B because… (answers vary) · 5 The book (that / which) I read was amazing. · 6 more confident · 7 She advised me to apply early. · 8 meeting